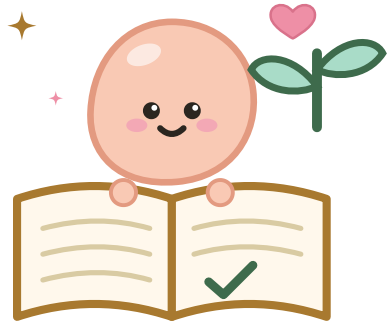
SPREAD LOVE & ACCEPTANCE · BOOK 1

Know Yourself Kindly

Where your lens came from, who you are now, and who you are becoming



by Christian

Independently published
spreadloveandacceptance.com

Spread Love & Acceptance, Book 1: *Know Yourself Kindly*.
By Christian. Independently published.

Text and pictures © 2026 Christian. First print edition, October 2026. Printed on demand.

Free online, always. Every chapter of the series is free to read at spreadloveandacceptance.com/book, with an expanded version that adds the research, more examples and more to try, and with no account and no paid version. The print books are optional. You may copy pages of this book for personal use and for non-commercial teaching, with credit to "Spread Love & Acceptance, spreadloveandacceptance.com."

Not therapy. This book is general education about people and relationships. It is not a diagnosis or a treatment, and it can't know your situation.

The examples are made up. The people in this book's examples are made up; any likeness to real people is coincidence. None of them is a testimonial.

The research the chapters mention is listed briefly at the back. The full list, with what each study found and links, is at spreadloveandacceptance.com/research.

Set in Lora, Fraunces and IBM Plex Mono.

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About this book, and how to use it

This book starts with you. It looks at where your way of seeing things came from, how you are wired today, how feelings work, why your worth was never a score, how personality works and how minds can work differently.

It is for anyone who wants to understand themselves a little better, at their own pace. You don't need a partner, a problem or a diagnosis to read it, and nothing in it is a test.

Read the chapters in any order. Each holds the core of a chapter. The expanded version of every chapter, with more research, more examples and more to try, is free to read online. The code at the end of each chapter opens it on your phone.

HERE	ABOUT	FREE ONLINE AT SPREADLOVEANDACCEPTANCE.COM/BOOK
Chapter 1	Where your lens came from	…/book/self-1-then
Chapter 2	Your wiring, weather and words	…/book/self-2-now
Chapter 3	Who you are becoming	…/book/self-3-next
Chapter 4	How feelings work	…/book/understanding-1-feelings
Chapter 5	Self-worth, shame and self-compassion	…/book/understanding-7-worth
Chapter 6	Personality, temperament and change	…/book/understanding-14-personality
Chapter 7	Minds that work differently	…/book/understanding-9-minds

Each book in the series stands on its own. Book 2, *Heal and Steady*, is about the heavy days. Book 3, *Understanding Each Other*, is about understanding the people around you. Book 4, *Share the Load*, is about sharing the work of a shared life. When a chapter mentions another book, it gives the book, the chapter and the page in that book, as in "Book 2, Chapter 1 (page 7)." The workbook, The Workpapers, has every form from the series on big pages.

FIVE BIG IDEAS

Five ideas run under the whole series.

- **See the whole load.** Count the unseen work too, the noticing, remembering and planning, yours and other people's.
- **Fix the setup, not the person.** When something keeps going wrong, change the arrangement around it before you blame anyone.
- **Read your state first.** How full your day already is changes how every word sounds, so check yourself before you react.
- **Tune how you send and receive.** People differ in pace, tone and wiring, and a mismatch is something to translate, never a fault.
- **Notice the quiet incentives.** Jobs nobody owns drift to whoever notices first, and a named owner and a real thank-you stop the drift.

Some chapters mention the six-week program, a free plan on the website with one small step a week (spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01). The workbook has a planner for it. The people in this book's examples are made up; any likeness to real people is coincidence.

Find it fast

Start with what is going on. Each line points to the chapter that helps most, and you can read that chapter on its own.

An old rule from home keeps steering you	Chapter 1 · Where your lens came from	7
Mornings, noise or crowds wear you out faster than other people	Chapter 2 · Your wiring, weather and words	25
You want to change one habit or one part you play	Chapter 3 · Who you are becoming	45
Feelings arrive in your body before you can name them	Chapter 4 · How feelings work	61
A mistake turns into “I’m useless”	Chapter 5 · Self-worth, shame and self-compassion	79
Your inner critic is loud	Chapter 5 · Self-worth, shame and self-compassion	79
You and someone close are built very differently	Chapter 6 · Personality, temperament and change	97
You wonder whether your mind works differently	Chapter 7 · Minds that work differently	115
Fitting in all day leaves you drained	Chapter 7 · Minds that work differently	115

Workpapers, tools and three friends

WORKPAPER WP-11 **A workpaper** is a page you fill in, on your own or together, such as "Workpaper WP-11: The Calm-Down Kit." Every workpaper is free to print or to fill out on the website, and the book gives a code to scan for each one. *The Workpapers: The Bound Edition* has them all in one place, on big pages.

TOOL **A tool** is a helper you use on the website, such as "Tool: Old rules, new choices." You use it and it gives you something back.

Workpapers and tools are kept in separate lists. Both are free and need no account, and what you type stays on your own device.

THREE FRIENDS WHO GIVE HINTS



Professor Puddles, a raindrop in a mortarboard, gives most of the hints, and answers questions on the website.



Tidbit, the quick, curious pup, points you at something to try.



Sugarfoot, the slower, steadier pup, turns up when a page needs a calmer pace.

They keep to the lighter pages.

FROM THE PERSON WHO MADE THIS

> *"I spent my career as a government auditor and audit manager in tax enforcement, internal controls and compliance." "Everyone else seemed to have been handed a set of instructions about being human that nobody ever gave me, so I went looking for them myself." "Everything here exists so that you can do the same thing in far less time than it took me."*

Christian, quoted from the About page at spreadloveandacceptance.com/about. Where the chapters say "I," they speak for the website and these books; any fact about Christian in them comes from that page.

1

BOOK 1 · CHAPTER 1

Know yourself: then, where your lens came from

Why you expect what you expect, and how the rules you picked up growing up still make small decisions for you today.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. You're not one thing
2. Your lens came from somewhere
3. Each stage of growing up asks its own question
4. When something happened matters
5. Some old answers were learned without all the facts
6. An old rule can read other people for you
7. Write down the rulebook from home
8. You get to choose which rules to keep
9. What you carry forward is yours
10. You, in all your relationships
11. When a reaction is older than today
12. Common mix-ups

SUNDAY, 10:15AM

Last night's pan is soaking on the stove, there's a can of tomatoes open by the kettle, and one of the three mugs has grown something. Your partner is asleep. You haven't had a single thought yet, not one, and already there's a voice going of course it's you, it's always you.

Nobody said that, and nobody else is even awake yet.

Across town Ray is drying a plate that nobody will ever see. His wife died two years ago, and he still can't sit down with the

> *paper until the last fork is back in the drawer. His mother couldn't either.*

A strong reaction can be read in quick strokes before it's read slowly. There's the moment itself, somebody late or a door shut too hard. Under it, today: sleep, hunger, the week. Under that, the rulebook you grew up with, and under that the root, which is mostly ownership and structure: who made the rules, and who gets to change them now. This chapter slows right down on the rulebook.

01

You're not one thing.

Dot is seventy-one and her son is forty minutes late for Sunday lunch. When he finally comes in, cold air and apologies and a bunch of gas-station carnations, she says, "Well, the beef's ruined," in a voice she will regret by dessert.

Three things went into that sentence. She has liked things on time since she was a girl; that's wiring, and it isn't going anywhere. Her father treated lateness as a kind of insult, and she picked that up without ever deciding to. And she was awake at four listening to the wind rattle the side gate. A strong reaction is usually all three at once, and it helps to know which one is shouting loudest. This chapter is about the middle one, what life taught you, and Chapter 2 (page 25) deals with the other two.

Dot doesn't say any of this. She says, "Sit down, then," and gives him the end bit, which he likes, and the rest of lunch is all right.

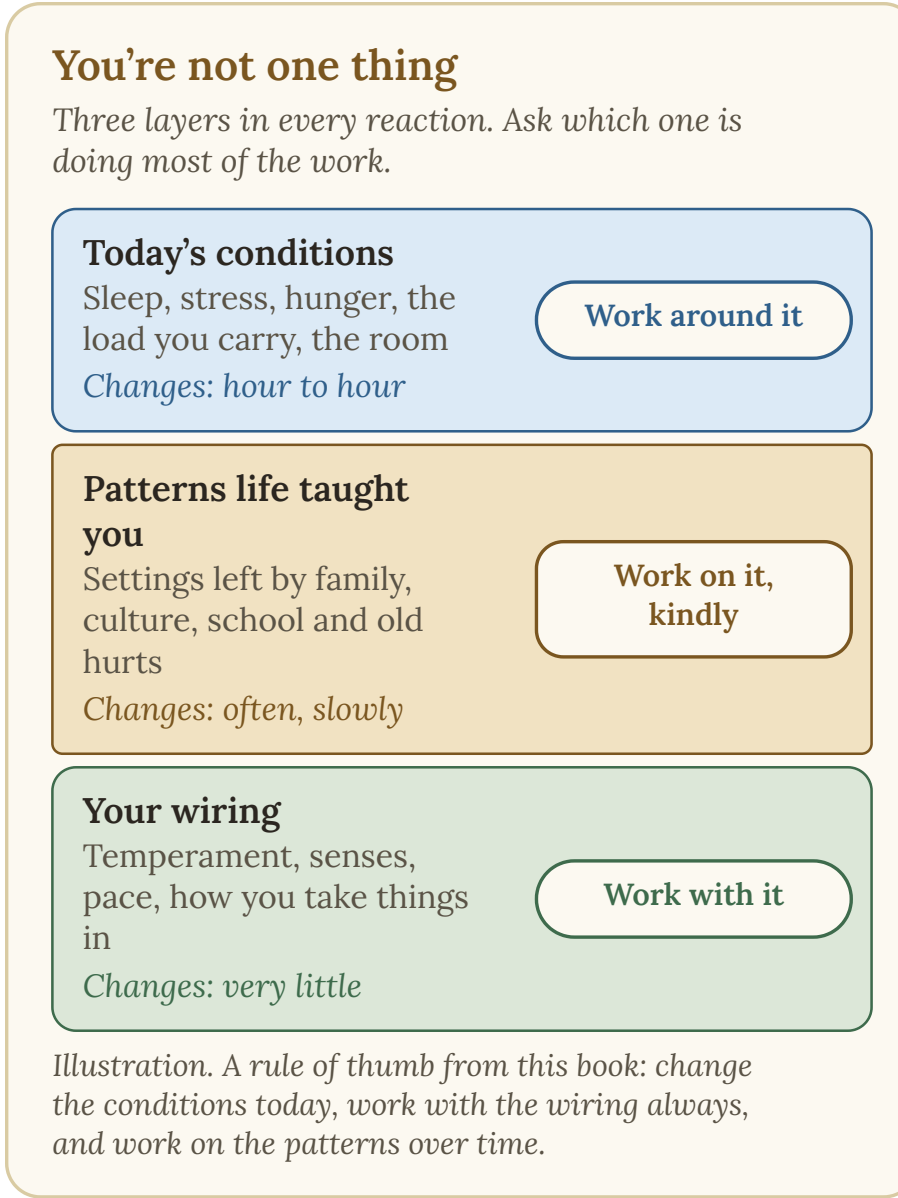


FIGURE 1 Three layers in every reaction. Each one changes at a different speed and needs a different move.

02

Your lens came from somewhere.

You learned what to expect from people long before you had words for it, at home mostly, but also at school and from whatever was on the TV at dinnertime. By the time you're grown up the lens doesn't feel like a lens anymore, it feels like simply seeing what's there.

Birthdays give it away. Imogen grew up with a party every year, a sheet cake, and cousins driving down from Baltimore with a balloon tied to the side mirror. Stuart got a card propped against the cornflakes and a slightly better dinner. So when Stuart books a quiet table for two on her thirtieth, he thinks he has nailed it. She spends the appetizers trying not to look at the door.

It took them two more birthdays to say it out loud. "In my family this was a big deal," she said in the end. "What was it like in yours?" He thought about it. "Mom made a pie." The free tool Old rules, new choices walks through the idea slowly, and you can read one section and stop.

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
Old rules, new choices
spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up

03

Each stage of growing up asks its own question.

A small child is working out whether the world is safe. A bit older and the questions change to whether you're any good at things, where you fit, and whether you can be close to someone without

disappearing into them. Later still, grown-ups start to wonder whether any of it has meant anything. What sticks is the answer you landed on at each stop, because you can go on using it for decades without noticing you're using it.

Jago moved schools four times between eleven and sixteen. He's forty-four now, a site manager, and on the first morning of every new contract he still stands by the site trailer feeling like the new kid with the wrong shoes. He only figured out why last year. I suspect most of us have one of those questions still running somewhere.

Eight questions in a life

The idea that each stage of life asks its own question goes back to Erik Erikson, who described eight of them, from trust against mistrust in a baby to identity against confusion in a teenager. Think of it as a way of looking back, not a schedule anyone has measured.

Erikson (1950) · *Theory: very influential; a framework for reflection, not a measured sequence*

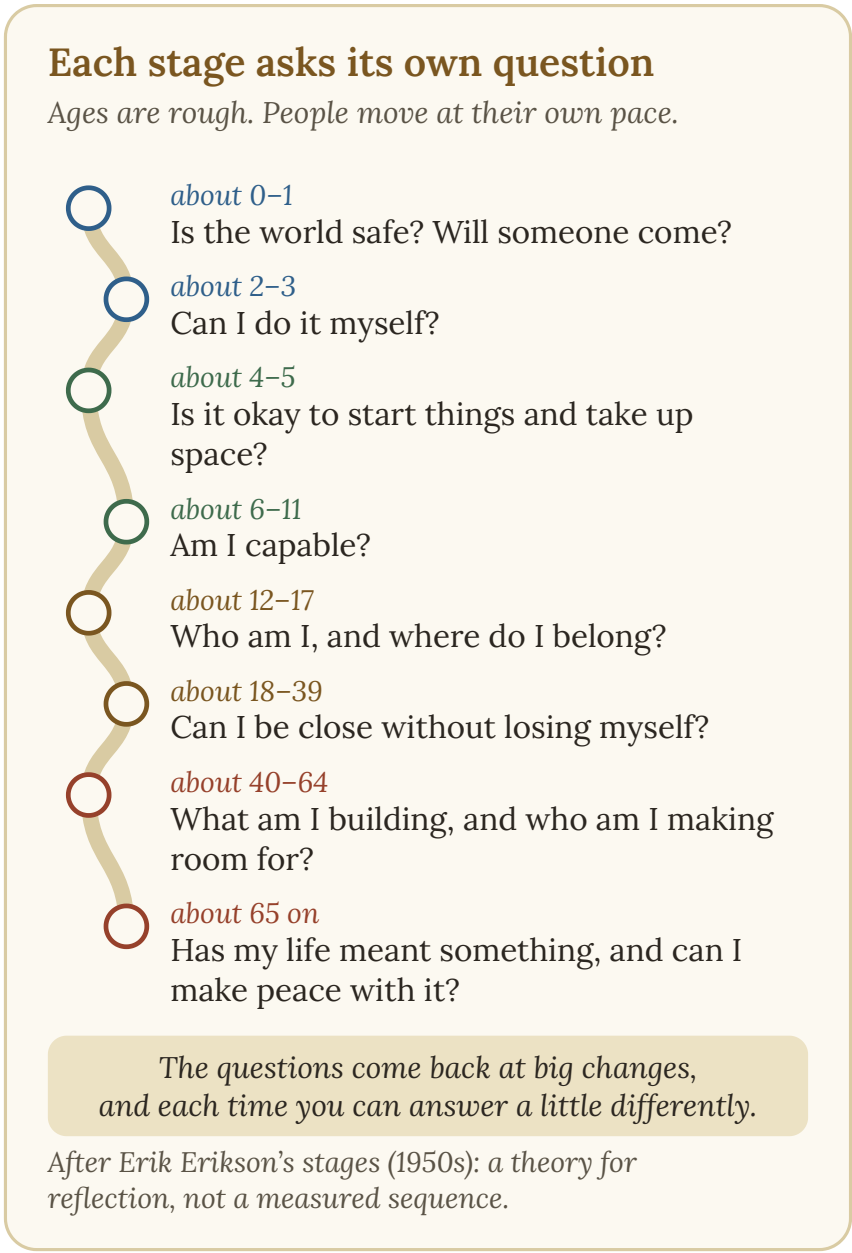


FIGURE 2 Each stage of life asks its own question. The ages are rough, and the questions come back at big changes (after Erik Erikson).

04

When something happened matters.

An experience goes deeper when it lands on the question you were busy with at the time. Moving at four is mostly about a new bedroom. Moving at fourteen, in the thick of working out where you belong, can leave you feeling on the outside for years.

Two sisters were six and fifteen when their parents split up. The younger one remembers glow-in-the-dark stars on her new ceiling and a different bus to school, and remembers it fondly, which drives her sister up the wall. The older one remembers every other Friday, standing in the hall with a duffel bag, being torn in two. They are both right, which is why that year still comes up at Christmas (see Family rifts, spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts). Deeper doesn't mean permanent. People go on learning all their lives.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Family rifts
spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts

05

Some old answers were learned without all the facts.

Plenty of adults carry a sentence about themselves that they picked up before they were old enough to check it. *I'm only all right when I'm useful. My needs are a nuisance. If I get it wrong, I'm bad.* A child can't see what is going on for the grown-ups, so they go by how the room felt, and they draw the only conclusion a child can draw, which is usually about themselves.

Sheila has fostered for eleven years and she's very good at it. She also can't ask for a weekend off, the planned weekend when someone else has the children, not even in the week she put the cereal in the fridge and the milk in the cupboard. "They've got enough on," she told her sister, who had called specifically to offer it.

Looking again as an adult doesn't mean deciding it was all fine back then. It means you're allowed the full picture now. Try writing down one old belief about yourself, then underneath it what you'd say to a friend who believed the same thing about themselves.

06

An old rule can read other people for you.

If silence at home meant someone was angry, then a partner's quiet evening can feel like weather coming in. And a rule nobody has ever said out loud can't be agreed to, so the other person can only break it. *If you loved me you'd just know. Whoever notices, does it.* Each is somebody's family rule, enforced on someone from a different family.

Gemma's roommate goes out at 7:10 without saying goodbye. Gemma, who grew up in a house where the door going without a word meant a fight was coming, spends the whole morning at work going over what she might have done. The roommate was on the 7:14 to a shift she'd nearly slept through.

If you catch yourself reading a silence, you can just ask. "You went off quick this morning. Everything all right?" Nine times out of ten it's a train.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

When an old rule jumps in before you've had a chance to think, you don't have to argue with it. Write it down, and look at it again on a calm day.

TOOL **Old rules, new choices** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Old rules, new choices
spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up

07

Write down the rulebook from home.

If you only do one exercise in this book, I'd make it this one. Finish these six lines the way the home you grew up in would have finished them.

"In my family, love looked like…" "When someone was upset, we…" "The jobs were split like this…" "Resting was okay when…" "Asking for help meant…" "The unforgivable thing was…"

The last one is usually the interesting one. The rulebook page has room to write them, and nothing is saved anywhere except on your own device.

Amira and Daniel did it one December, after Daniel's mom had asked about Christmas again and Amira had gone very quiet. Somewhere on each of their pages, in different words, was the same rule. Christmas belongs to my family. It explained four years of tug of war in one go, and they laughed, a bit, before the actual negotiating started (see Two faiths, one family,

spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths). One line today is plenty. If you show it to someone, you might say, "This is a rule I grew up with. I'm not saying it's right. I just want you to know it's there."

Rules handed down

Family therapists in the Bowen tradition look at a family as one emotional unit, with roles passed from one generation to the next, which is more or less what your rulebook lines catch. It's influential in practice and lightly tested in research, so I'd hold it loosely.

Kerr and Bowen (1988) · *Debated: influential in family therapy, limited testing*

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 1

The rulebook from home

A person on their own

Your rulebook from home

Write a few words on each line, the way the home you grew up in would have finished it. Skip any line you like. Then, for each one, ask: do I still want this rule?

1. In my family, love looked like…

Doing things. Dad fixed your bike; nobody said it.

Do I still want this rule?

Keep (*Soften*) Drop

2. When someone was upset, we…

Went quiet and waited for it to pass.

Do I still want this rule?

Keep (*Soften*) Drop

3. The jobs were split like this…

Mom noticed, planned and remembered. Dad did the big jobs.

Do I still want this rule?

Keep Soften (*Drop*)

4. Resting was okay when…
Everything else was done.

Do I still want this rule?

Keep Soften *Drop*

5. Asking for help meant…
You hadn't planned well enough.

Do I still want this rule?

Keep Soften *Drop*

6. The unforgivable thing was…
Breaking a promise.

Do I still want this rule?

Keep Soften Drop

Fill in your own: The rulebook from home

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
rulebook page
spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up

ONLINE
Two faiths, one family
spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths

08

You get to choose which rules to keep.

Go back over your lines and ask of each one whether you still want it. Some you'll keep. Some you'll look at and think, well, that one can go.

When a reaction feels too big for the moment, wait till you've settled and give it a minute's questioning. Where did I learn this? How old does it feel? Is it true here, with this person, today?

Bev runs a team at a credit union and realized, eventually, that she hid problems from her manager until they were too big to hide, because at home a mistake meant a mood that lasted days. She wrote a new rule on a yellow sticky note and stuck it to the bottom of her monitor. *Mistakes are information. We fix them together.* Three years on it has gone curly, and she won't take it down.

Pick one of your rules and write the version you'd rather live by. "I used to think ___. Now I'm choosing ___." Later, if you like, swap rulebooks with someone you trust and pick some shared rules on purpose.

09

What you carry forward is yours.

You didn't choose the home you grew up in, or what anyone else did, or what you concluded at seven about how things work. What's in your hands now is smaller than that and a good deal sturdier. You decide which rules you keep. You decide how you talk to yourself about them, and where your energy goes, and that includes people. Give your care where it's met with care. Where it's all one way, let it shrink back to something that feels fair, so you have some left.

Marcia has organized every meet-up with an old school friend for nine years, and the friend always comes, always seems pleased, and has never once in all that time suggested a date. Last spring Marcia stopped chasing. She sent one message ("I'd love to see you, let me know when works") and then nothing, which was harder than it sounds. The friend didn't reply for five weeks, and in those five weeks Marcia went to a quiz, twice, with people who did reply (see Always the one reaching out?).

Is there somewhere you give far more than comes back? You could give a little less there this month and see what happens.



FIGURE 3 Where your lens came from, how you run today and who you are becoming, in one picture. You choose what you carry forward.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Always the one reaching out?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends

TUESDAY, 11:30

Two people get the same text from the same friend. Can we talk tonight? Fern is pleased, because she likes a plan. Callum feels his stomach go, because in his house "we need to talk" never once meant anything good, and he spends his lunch hour sitting in the car rehearsing answers to accusations nobody has made.

The friend wanted to know if they were still up for splitting a cabin in Maine in August. Callum said yes too quickly and then had to call back about the dates.

TWO WAYS TO READ THIS

A rule from home

BOTH DIRECTIONS Some brains take a rule at its word. "We don't make a fuss" gets learned literally, and kept, long after anyone meant it. Other brains pick the rule up from the air of a room and couldn't tell you the words at all. If yours is the first kind, the other person's rule may sound vague. Ask for the plain version. If it's the second, theirs may sound oddly rigid. It may simply be the only version they were ever given.

WHERE THE FIELDS MEET Politics would call a family a small government: the rules were made before you could vote on them. Philosophy adds a sorting habit, the fact from the guess, and a rule learned at six is often a guess that hardened into a fact.

You, in all your relationships

Your old rules come with you everywhere, starting with the voice you use on yourself after a mistake. At home they decide who notices, who plans and what a quiet evening means. Two roommates can share a fridge for a year before finding out they've been living by different rulebooks about mess. In families, the old roles switch back on before you've got your coat off (the helper, the peacemaker, the one who makes it funny). At work, someone

praised mainly for being useful says yes to everything and then quietly seethes, and seeing the rule is often enough to buy them a pause before the next yes. After a breakup old rules can get louder, which makes it a good time to look at them kindly (see On my own, spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own). How you connect is a two-minute quiz on the talking rules you brought with you. Help by relationship lists pages for many more situations.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
On my own
spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own

TOOL
How you connect: the 2-minute style quiz
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength

ONLINE
Help by relationship
spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship

When a reaction is older than today

Some of what you learned at home, at school or in your first relationships still sets off reactions now, and some of it came from hard or frightening times. You might notice a reaction that feels older than the moment, arrives in your body before you can think, or follows the same kind of trigger each time. That isn't a flaw, and having lived through something hard is never your fault. The aim is to take back control, so the old event stops running today. Notice it ("this feels older than today"), name it, steady your body, and then choose what to do next. How hurt heals (Book 2, Chapter 5, page 81) goes further into how old hurts shape new reactions.

Common mix-ups

The worry people bring to this chapter most often is that looking back means blaming their family. It doesn't have to. Many of the adults who raised us had lenses of their own, and if that doesn't fit your story, you don't have to make it fit. Then there's the fear that anything which started in childhood is fixed for good. Many old patterns soften once you can see them and feel safe enough to try something else, and some leave a lasting sensitivity that you learn to carry and explain. Not every big reaction is an old wound, either. Quite often it's just a full tank (Book 4, Chapter 3, page 51, helps you tell leftover stress from this-moment stress). And some people decide there's no point looking at their own rules if the other person won't look at theirs. I don't agree with that one at all. Knowing your own rules changes how you react whether or not anyone else reads a word of this.

> **A note on care:** This part looks back at growing up. It is general education, not a diagnosis or therapy, and it can't tell you what anyone has. Not every home felt calm or kind, so take only what is useful. If looking back feels heavy, you can stop and come back another day. Nothing here is required, and nothing you write needs to be shared.

If you want to go on, notice one "always" or "never" that went through your head this week. Whose voice was it in? How old did you feel? Where your lens came from, Roots & Wings and Know your own wiring go further.

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Old rules, new choices
spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up

ONLINE
Know your own wiring
spreadloveandacceptance.com/know-yourself

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ You're not one thing.
- ✓ Each stage of growing up asks its own question.
- ✓ Some old answers were learned without all the facts.
- ✓ Write down the rulebook from home.
- ✓ What you carry forward is yours.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 3, Chapter 3 · How we see each other
How a lens shapes what you notice in other people
Understanding Each Other, page 45

Book 3, Chapter 4 · Attachment, trust and belonging
How early trust and attachment carry into adult life
Understanding Each Other, page 61

Chapter 6 · Personality, temperament and change
Which parts are temperament, and which can change
page 97

Book 2, Chapter 5 · Healing after hurt
Making peace with what happened, and with old hurts
Heal and Steady, page 81

PUT IT TO USE

The self path: see where your lens came from

spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path

Go deeper (free online) The expanded version of this chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-1-then-in-depth

2

BOOK 1 · CHAPTER 2

Know yourself: now, your wiring, your weather and your words

Why the same words can land differently on different days and in different people, and how to understand today's you well enough to say what helps.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Today is made of two layers you can work with
2. Know how you like to be spoken to
3. Check your weather before you speak
4. Ask where this feeling is coming from
5. Plan what settles you on a calm day
6. Your needs and limits are information, not demands
7. Being wired differently is not being wrong
8. Explain yourself without over-sharing
9. Do your part, and only your part
10. You, in all your relationships
11. Common mix-ups

SUNDAY, 7:50PM

Your friend pauses the movie. "*You okay? You've been quiet all day.*"

"*Fine.*"

Which isn't a lie, exactly. You genuinely don't know if you're fine, or tired, or still chewing on something somebody said on Thursday. You couldn't explain it to yourself, never mind to her. You reach for the remote and she lets you.

Quickly first. A flat "Fine." on a Sunday evening is the surface. Under it sits the wiring, how much noise and change you can take in before it costs you. Under that sits the weather, how much sleep and food and week you've had. The roots are state and setting, and limited capacity. Now slowly, one layer at a time.

01

Today is made of two layers you can work with.

Your wiring is the lasting part, your temperament and pace and senses and the way words go in, and you work *with* that, by building a life that suits it. Today's conditions are the passing part (sleep, hunger, the hour) and you work *around* those, usually by eating something or sleeping on it. Most of the frustration here comes from mixing the two up. (Chapter 1, page 7, covers the third layer, the patterns life taught you.)

Dean works nights at a distribution center. For months the school drop-off chatter at 8:10 was unbearable to him, all of it, the who-sat-next-to-who and the who-said-what in PE, and he started quietly wondering whether he was any good at being a dad. Then his partner swapped with him, so he does the 3:30 pickup now, after he's slept, and the same chatter is funny again (see Different hours, spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours). His daughter told her teacher that her dad has "got nicer," which he found out about at the parent-teacher conference.

Write down one thing that always bothers you, which is probably wiring, and then one that only bothers you when you're tired.

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
Different hours
spreadloveandacceptance.
com/different-hours

02

Know how you like to be spoken to.

Pace, tone, how much needs spelling out and what a silence means all change how words land. How you connect gives you words for it, and a four-letter Wave Code that's meant to be light-hearted, so please don't put it on your resume. The "How to talk to me" card fits the same thing onto one page you can hand over before a hard talk.

Agnes is seventy-two and loves a phone call. Her grandson Liam loves a text and regards the phone ringing as a kind of emergency. For about a year each of them privately decided the other had gone a bit cool. It took a cousin, over the pie at Christmas, to say, "Grandma, he's not ignoring you, he just doesn't answer the phone. To anyone. Ever." There's a Sunday call at six now, with texts in between, and Liam mostly picks up.

If you want somewhere to start, finish this. "I take things in best when…"

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 2

“How to talk to me” card

Made alone, to give to a friend

Your card

Pick what is usually true for you. Add a few words where the buttons are not enough. Leave a line blank if it does not apply.

Who it’s for

A partner Family (A *friend*) Work (a manager or coworker)

Name on the card, optional

Ife

WIRING CARD · NOT A DIAGNOSIS

How I receive things best
In writing. One thing at a time.

I take words
Literally when it matters, tone when it is light.

Give me time to answer
A few minutes.

If I go quiet, it means
I’m thinking.

Please avoid
Long texts or many topics at once.

A request lands best as
The ask in the first sentence.

Applies more strictly when I am running low. Not a contract, and not a label. Change it when it stops being true.

Fill in your own: “How to talk to me” card

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
How you connect: the 2-minute style quiz
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength



TOOL
How you connect: how I like to be spoken to
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card

03

Check your weather before you speak.

Everything you hear goes through your own state on the way in. Book 4, Chapter 3 (page 51) looks closely at the stress tank in a shared home. This chapter only adds the self side, a one-minute reading on your own before you decide what a hard moment means, and for that My weather today is the quick check and How much are you carrying? the fuller one, on a short worksheet.

A couple living five hours apart worked out, eventually, that every bad call they'd had came at the end of her late shift, around midnight her time. Every single one. They moved anything serious to Saturday mornings, with coffee, and found they mostly agreed with each other (see Long distance, spreadloveandacceptance.com/long-distance).

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
>
> "I'm running on empty tonight. Can we pick this up tomorrow morning?"

ONE STATE, MANY WORDS. The chapters and tools use a few everyday pictures for one thing, how much room you have today.

- **The three states** (Book 2, Chapter 1, page 7, calls them the ladder) are calm and connected, revved up, and running on empty.
- **My weather today** uses sky words for the same three. *Clear* is calm and connected, *gusty* is revved up, and *fogged in* is running on empty. Its *pressure* is how much you were already carrying.
- **The stress tank** is the score from How much are you carrying?, from 0 to 1, where higher means fuller.
- **The battery** is the other side of the tank, the energy you have left, so a full tank means a low battery.

"Gusty," "revved up," "a fairly full tank" and "a low battery" can all describe the same Tuesday afternoon. I'd pick one set and stick with it.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 3

My weather today

A person on their own, after a short night

Check today's weather

The sky

Clear: Calm and connected | *Gusty: Revved up* | Fogged in: Running on empty

Who you'll mostly be around today

A partner | Family | A co-parent | Roommates | Coworkers | Someone I care for | Friends | *Mostly on my own*

The pressure

Light *Building* Heavy

Ground conditions

Haven't eaten in a while Thirsty In pain or unwell Been still all day

Too much noise or light Running on caffeine Screens since I woke up

Last night's sleep

Barely slept *Short night* About enough Properly rested

People load

Barely any A normal amount *A lot* Nonstop, no gaps

What's blowing in

Work Money Kids or caring Health Family The house

One conversation Something I can't name

What would actually help in the next hour?

Space *Food or water* Rest *To move* To be heard A plan

Company Quiet Someone to take something off me

YOUR FORECAST

Gusty today
Revved up · Some room today

Pace
go gently, settle first

It's gusty. You're revved up. That energy is useful for doing something physical, but it is poor weather for big decisions.

You said what would help is food or water and to move. Arrange that before anything else.

Overall: some room today. There is less room than usual, so spend it carefully.

If you want to send someone a line: "I'm a bit wound up today, so I'll keep replies short. It isn't about you."

Fill in your own: My weather today

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
My weather today
spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

ONLINE
Long distance
spreadloveandacceptance.com/long-distance

04

Ask where this feeling is coming from.

It's 4:45 on a Friday and a colleague leans over the partition. "Quick question?"

Your heart goes. Why? If you stop and look, there's a fair bit in there. A jumpiness that belongs to a manager you had six years ago, who never once had a quick question. A long week. And nothing to eat since a cookie at eleven. What it needs is five minutes and a sandwich, and then you can answer him like a normal person.

That's the whole check, really: name the feeling, roughly, then ask whether it fits the size of the moment or feels older, and what it needs. The answer is usually more ordinary than you'd think, and it works best once the first wave has gone past.

When feelings are hard to name. For some people "What are you feeling?" is a hard question most days and nearly impossible on bad ones. They notice a racing heart or a heavy stomach and can't tell if it's worry or hunger or something else. Psychologists call this *alexithymia*, which means "no words for feelings." It's a trait that runs from a little to a lot. It's common, especially among autistic people, and it isn't an illness. The feelings are there. The words come slowly. Start with the body ("tight chest, skipped lunch"). Pick between two words instead of hunting for one ("more tired or

more annoyed?"). Use the sky words if feeling words won't come. "I'll tell you tomorrow" is a real answer.

Where is this feeling coming from?

Four small questions, once the first wave has passed.

1. **Name it**
   A word or two is enough. Or start with the body: where do you feel it?
2. **Now, or older?**
   Is the feeling the size of the moment, or is something left over?
3. **Which layer?**
   Wiring, an old pattern, or today's conditions. Pick the biggest part.
4. **What does it need?**
   Food, rest or space. A heads-up. A fact check. A talk later, once settled.

This book's own four steps. Finding words for feelings is hard for many people; the body is a good place to start.

FIGURE 4 A four-step self-check for a feeling that is bigger than you expected. Do it once the first wave has passed.

05

Plan what settles you on a calm day.

Halfway through being wound up is a terrible time to work out what calms you down, so the Calm-Down Kit is a plan you make beforehand, with what tends to set you off, two things that help, and one sentence for stepping away that says when you'll be back. It's for you. It is never a list of instructions for anyone else.

Elsie is fourteen and she and her mom have the same fight about her phone roughly twice a week. She made a kit, grudgingly, mostly to get her mom off her back. The next time it kicked off she said, "I need ten minutes, I'll come back," and went upstairs and lay on her bed with her headphones in, furious. Twelve minutes later she came down to find her mom had made some tea. Neither of them mentioned the phone, which wasn't exactly a resolution, and was a great deal better than the usual.

> YOU COULD SAY
>
> "I need ten minutes. I'll be back at a quarter after."



SUGARFOOT

Make your calm-down plan on a slow, quiet day, feet up, cup of tea. Making one in the middle of a storm is like reading the instructions on the fire extinguisher while the pan's still burning.

WORKPAPER WP-11 **The Calm-Down Kit** · free to print
· spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

SCAN TO OPEN

WORKPAPER WP-11 · free to print
The Calm-Down Kit
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

06

Your needs and limits are information, not demands.

What helps you and what you've got left are facts about you. Said kindly, they let other people plan around you. "A heads-up helps me." "I can do this one. Not that one." "I'm low today, can it wait till tomorrow?" You don't have to justify a need. A reason is a kindness you can add if you want to.

For years I was told I was too sensitive and too particular about plans, and what was actually true is that I need less coming at me at once, and I need to know what's coming. Heard as complaints, needs like that sound like things to fix in you. Understood as needs, they're simply things to arrange.

Quinn lives with his two partners in a row house with one bathroom and an alarming number of shoes in the hall. He needs an hour on his own after work, and before he said so, that hour looked to everyone else like sulking. Once he'd said it, plainly, it turned into part of the week, like trash day, and one of the others now makes dinner on Thursdays.

Needs as plain facts

Marshall Rosenberg's Nonviolent Communication teaches people to say what they saw, what they feel, what they need and what they'd like. It's very widely used and has had few rigorous studies. The piece borrowed here is small: a need, said as a fact about you.

Rosenberg (1999) · *Early: a widely used practice with few rigorous studies*

Two workpapers from other chapters help with the words. Who did what, from Book 4, Chapter 1 (page 7), has ready-made kind ways to say no. Say it so it lands, from Book 4, Chapter 4 (page 73), turns a raw reaction into a plain request. Or try this. Write one need you've never said out loud, and say it to the bathroom mirror without the apology on the front.

07

Being wired differently is not being wrong.

Some people take in words, noise, change and feelings differently from the way most social customs were built, and that's wiring, which you can understand and plan around if you want. Shona has ADHD and spent years calling herself hopeless because she kept missing plans with friends. Now she just tells people the one thing that works, a text the day before, and she turns up, usually on time and always with an apology ready in case (see Neurodivergent relationships, spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships).

A mix-up runs both ways. When an autistic and a non-autistic person misread each other, the autistic person usually gets the blame. The *double empathy problem*, named by the autistic researcher Damian Milton, is the idea that the gap runs both ways. Each person reads the other through their own way of communicating, and each finds the other hard to read. In one study, a story passed along a chain of autistic people kept as much detail as one passed along non-autistic people, while mixed chains lost detail faster. I find that study quietly cheering. Wired Differently shows how two differently wired people can each misread the other, and "Where did we lose each other?" lets both of you adjust a little.

"Putting on my best normal"
That's the title of a study in which 92 autistic adults described camouflaging their differences, mostly out of a wish to fit in and connect, and often paying for it afterward in exhaustion. If a perfectly nice day leaves you flattened, it may be worth asking how much of it you spent performing.

Hull and colleagues (2017) · *Moderate: an interview study that shaped later research*

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Neurodivergent relationships
spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships

ONLINE
Wired Differently
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wired-differently

08

Explain yourself without over-sharing.

Most moments need one short sentence, and there are really only three. “This is how I’m wired, it won’t change, but this helps.” “This is an old alarm going off, I’m working on it.” “Low-battery day, sorry.” You never owe anyone your history, only the bit that helps them help you.

Rob has a long-term illness and a new friend from the climbing wall who keeps suggesting things. “Some days I’ve got less in the tank,” he told him, on the bench, unlacing his shoes. “If I cancel, it isn’t you.” The friend said “Fair enough” and asked if he wanted a ride on Thursday, and that was the end of it, with no medical notes required (see When one of you is sick or disabled, spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill).

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
When one of you is sick or disabled
spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill

09

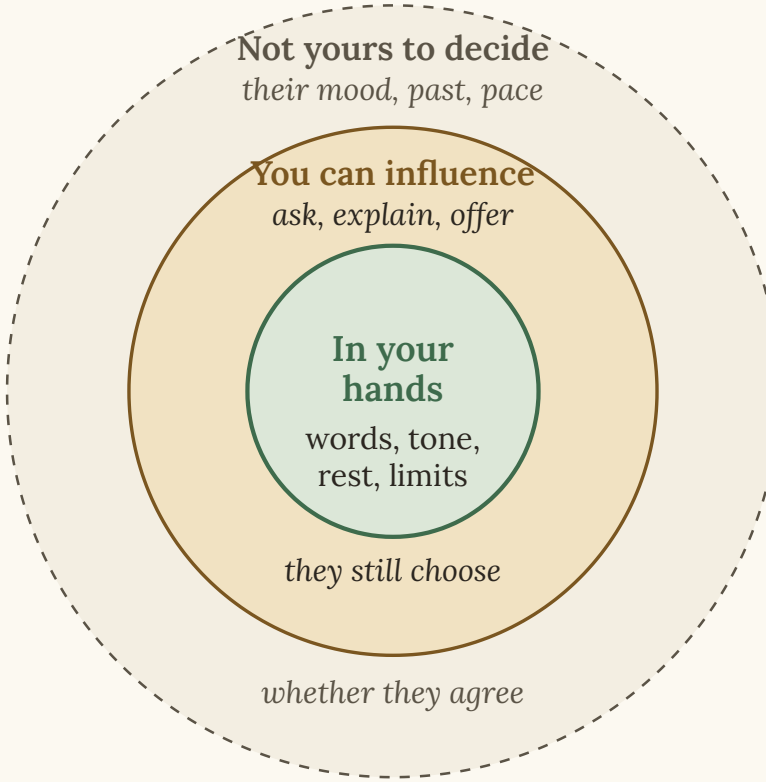
Do your part, and only your part.

Today you control your own words, your effort, your rest, your limits and what you ask for. You don't control anyone else's mood or pace, and trying to will flatten you quicker than almost anything. It helps, too, to match energy with energy. Meet warmth with warmth, and give a little less where you keep giving far more than comes back.

Lorna is thirty-eight and her dad still worries about her driving. She has tried reassurance, statistics and once, unwisely, sarcasm, and none of it worked. What she does now is text "Home safe x" after any long run up I-95, and then she lets his worry be his (see For grown-up children, spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children). He still worries, and she has stopped trying to talk him out of it.

Your circle of control

Spend your energy from the middle out.



Most exhaustion comes from pouring energy into the outer ring.

Illustration.

FIGURE 5 Your circle of control. Spend your energy from the middle out. Most exhaustion comes from pouring it into the outer ring.

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
For grown-up children
spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children

FRIDAY, 6:40PM

"Surprise! I've booked us dinner with my cousins tonight. Seven thirty, the Turkish place."

They meant it as a present. Your chest went tight and you heard yourself say "Great" in a voice with all the life ironed out of it. Later, at the sink, you try to work out which bit that was, the plan changing or something older or just the end of the week, and decide it was probably some of each. You still haven't said anything, and the taxi's booked for ten after.

TWO WAYS TO READ THIS

Leaving early without a long goodbye

FROM OUTSIDE Partway through a party, someone slips out with a quick wave.

THE LOGIC Energy works like a budget. This evening spent it faster than expected. Staying past empty risks a shutdown or a sharp word. Leaving quietly protects the evening and the friendship.

IT'S LIKE A phone on 3% that switches off everything except the call.

WHY IT FITS A long goodbye costs energy too, and there is very little left by then.

THE OTHER SIDE The host may wonder what went wrong, or whether you had a bad time.

YOU COULD SAY *"I had a good time. When my battery goes, I need to go quickly."*

ONE SMALL STEP Send a short thank-you text the next morning.

BOTH DIRECTIONS If your wiring takes in noise, light and change at full volume, a busy room can use up the day's energy by lunchtime, and needing a quiet hour afterward is simply the bill. If your wiring filters more of it out, the same room may feel lively and fine, and the quiet hour can look like sulking. Neither is the right way to be built. Each person mostly needs the other to believe their account of what it costs.

WHERE THE FIELDS MEET Neurobiology's version is that your state sets the volume: a body on high alert hears every comment louder. Aromatherapy, read modestly, makes the same point about the setting, that softer light or a quieter room can help some people slow down. The claims about particular oils are debated, and nothing here leans on them.

More situations like this one, each in the same six parts, are free online.
spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=left-party

You, in all your relationships

Your wiring and your weather come with you everywhere, starting with how you treat yourself on a bad day. Noticing that you're low ought to come before deciding that you're failing. Partners can give each other a heads-up or a quiet hour, and every partner has

wiring of their own. With friends and family, the question is usually how you like to keep in touch and how much you can give this month. At work it might be an agenda the day before, or a minute before you answer. Roommates mostly negotiate noise, and the bathroom. If you live on your own, you get to build a week that fits how you're built (see On my own, spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own).

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
On my own
spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own

Common mix-ups

Knowing yourself is mostly about what helps. A label can come later, or never, and the three layers and a Wave Code are everyday words with no diagnosis in them. "That's just how I am" may well be true, especially about wiring, but it works much better as the start of a conversation than the end of one. Telling people how you're wired doesn't make them your managers either, though it does help your words land. You still do your part, and they still have needs of their own.

And "I'm fine" does sometimes mean fine. Sometimes it means you've been tired for so long you've stopped noticing. A quick reading once a week shows you the baseline you've got used to, which can be a bit of a shock.

> **A note on care:** This part is general education. It isn't a diagnosis, a test or treatment, and it can't tell you whether you're autistic, have ADHD or anything else, or what anyone else has. Nothing here is required, and nothing you try needs to be shared.

To put this to use, take one reaction you had this week and give it a line for each layer (the wiring bit, the older bit, today's bit). Then take a one-minute reading of your weather. Then write one sentence about what helps you, and keep it to yourself for a few days before trying it on someone. Know your own wiring, the "How to talk to me" card and How much are you carrying? are free on the site.

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
Know your own wiring
spreadloveandacceptance.com/know-yourself



TOOL
How you connect: how I like to be spoken to
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card



WORKPAPER WP-02 · free to print
How much are you carrying?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-02

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ Today is made of two layers you can work with.
- ✓ Check your weather before you speak.
- ✓ Plan what settles you on a calm day.
- ✓ Being wired differently is not being wrong.
- ✓ Do your part, and only your part.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Chapter 7 · Minds that work differently
Wiring differences: autism, ADHD and the senses — page 115

Book 2, Chapter 1 · Stress and the nervous system
Why your weather changes how you hear things — Heal and Steady, page 7

Book 4, Chapter 3 · Full tanks and different angles
The stress tank, used between two people — Share the Load, page 51

Book 4, Chapter 4 · Two kinds of fair
What fair means when you share the work — Share the Load, page 73

PUT IT TO USE



The self path: get to know your wiring
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path



How much are you carrying? A quick stress check
Workpaper · free to print
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-02



Go deeper (free online) The expanded version of this chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now-in-depth

3

BOOK 1 · CHAPTER 3

Know yourself: next, shaping who you are becoming

You aren't finished, and some of who you become is up to you. This chapter is about choosing a direction and building small steps that still work on a tired day.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Start with what matters to you
2. Pick one small goal, in plain words
3. Name what gets in the way
4. Make the step tiny, and repeatable
5. Decide ahead with a simple if-then
6. Ask for support, as information
7. Look back kindly once a month
8. Kindness to yourself is part of the plan
9. Set goals inside your circle, and spend energy where it comes back
10. You, in all your relationships
11. Common mix-ups

WEDNESDAY, 9:10PM

The sneakers have been by the front door since Sunday, laces tucked in, pointing outward like a promise. You were going to walk after dinner, and dinner was two hours ago. Monday, you think. Monday has a nice clean feel to it.

Seen fast, a missed walk is three things stacked up. On the surface, sneakers by the door. Underneath, a plan sized for your best day rather than your worst. Underneath that, the old voice that says you never stick to anything. The roots here are feedback loops and balance. The rest of the chapter takes them in turn.

01

Start with what matters to you.

A goal built on somebody else's idea of a good life is very hard to keep going with. So before you pick one, ask what you want your days to feel like, and write two or three plain words. Calm, say, or close to family, or steady, or making things, and whatever they are, they give you a direction to face instead of a score to hit. If you're not sure what fills you up and what drains you, How you connect can help you notice.

The week their youngest went off to college, Marion and Keith each wrote two words on the back of a gas bill, hers saying "useful, outdoors" and his "calm, curious," and Keith looked at hers for a long while before he said, "That's why you keep going on about the bird hut." She had been eyeing the volunteers' hut at the nature reserve since February. He had been spending a suspicious amount of time staring at the vegetable garden (see Empty nest, spreadloveandacceptance.com/empty-nest). Write yours in pencil, since they may well change.

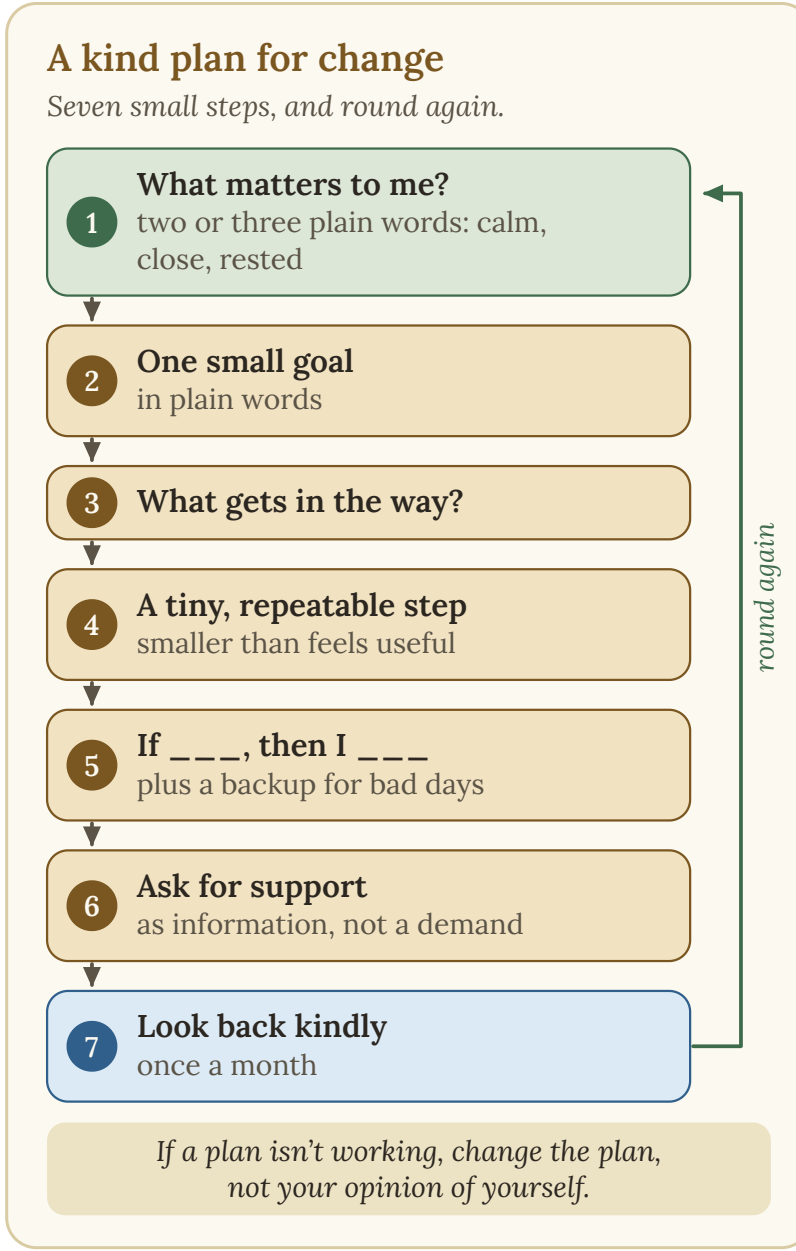


FIGURE 6 A kind plan for change in seven small steps. If the plan isn't working, change the plan, not your opinion of yourself.

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
How you connect: the 2-minute style quiz
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength

ONLINE
Empty nest
spreadloveandacceptance.com/empty-nest

02

Pick one small goal, in plain words.

Just one, and say it as something you'll do. "Walk for ten minutes after dinner" can go in a diary. "Get healthier" is a hope, and hopes are lovely, but you can't do anything with one on a Tuesday. Your own actions are up to you, while how people respond, and how it all turns out, aren't.

A student in a shared room in the dorms wanted to be "less messy," which her roommate had heard before. As an action it became "clothes in the basket before bed." She managed it about four nights in seven, and her roommate said that was four more than last semester (see Sharing a room, spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room). Try rewriting one wish so it starts "I will…"

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Plan it once: room agreement for roommates
spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room

03

Name what gets in the way.

This is where Chapter 1 (page 7) and Chapter 2 (page 25) earn their keep. The obstacle might be your wiring, and a plan that ignores how you're built was made for somebody else. It might be an old rule ("rest has to be earned" is a popular one), or it might simply be a tired Tuesday. Whichever it is, change the arrangement and leave yourself alone.

Kofi kept missing his evening run and had more or less decided the problem was his willpower, when the truth was that he works in a warehouse on a schedule that changes every single week, so "evenings" meant something different every Monday and his plan never stood a chance. Once he tied the run to his first day off, whenever it fell, he stopped missing it. He's still slightly annoyed it took him a year to see (see Different hours, spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours).

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Different hours
spreadloveandacceptance.
com/different-hours

04

Make the step tiny, and repeatable.

It needs to be small enough to survive your worst week, which means "Put my shoes on" counts, and I do mean that. Tie it to something you already do, and do it often. The 90-second daily check-in in Book 3, Chapter 1 (page 7) runs on the same idea, that small and often outlasts big and rare, and Ten-minute start shows how small a whole path can be.

Six months after the breakup, Ade wanted to "get back out there," which is far too big a thing to start on a Sunday night. What he actually did was send one message to one friend every Sunday, usually from the sofa during the weather forecast and usually something feeble like "you watching this?" and after a few weeks two of the friends started replying with whole paragraphs (see On my own, spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own). If you like a game for this sort of thing, the Re-check Drive turns small steps into calm football. If your step takes more than two minutes, shrink it again.

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Ten-minute start
spreadloveandacceptance.com/start-in-10-minutes

ONLINE
On my own
spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own

TOOL
Gentle games: the Re-check Drive (calm football)
spreadloveandacceptance.com/recheck-drive

05

Decide ahead with a simple if-then.

"If it's after dinner, I put my shoes on." Deciding ahead means one decision fewer on a tired day. It's the same thinking as the Calm-Down Kit, made while you're calm.

Handovers with her ex had been going badly for a year, so Kerry made a rule for the car. When she pulls up outside his house she turns the engine off and takes three slow breaths before she opens the door. It doesn't make him any less irritating, but it does mean she gets out of the car as herself (see Co-parenting, spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting).

Pick a cue that happens every day anyway, like the kettle or brushing your teeth. If the if-then doesn't work, change it.

If-then plans hold up

This is one of the better-supported ideas in the book. Across 94 tests, Gollwitzer and Sheeran found that plans in the form "when X happens, I'll do Y" had a medium-to-large effect on people reaching their goals, though the size varied with the task.

Gollwitzer and Sheeran (2006) · *Strong: one of the more robust findings in behavior change*

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 4

The Calm-Down Kit, just for me

A person on their own

The Calm-Down Kit

Your name
Nell

Date
October 11, 2026

Part A: What tends to start it

What tends to start it	How it shows up in my body first
A long message from my sister late at night	*Tight chest, typing fast*
Plans changed with no warning	*Jaw, hot face*

Part A: My two defaults

First default
Walking it out

Second, if the first isn't available
Asymmetric breathing (4 in, 6 out)

Part A: My pause line

In my words
I'm at capacity. I'm going to step away for twenty minutes, and I'll answer properly after that.

My pause plan (yours to share, if you like)

My pause word or signal
"Back in a bit"

The shortest break I take
20 minutes

How I set the time to come back
I text a time, the same day

The first sentence when I come back
"Thanks for waiting. I can think straight now."

Part B: In the moment

Say your pause word or line, then do your first calming step. Nothing in this kit works by cold, pain or shock, and none of it is treatment.

Part C: Coming back

Time	What I did	How I feel now
9:40pm	*Walking it out*	*Still hot*
10:05pm	*Asymmetric breathing (4 in, 6 out)*	*Settled enough*

WHERE THAT LEAVES YOU

Next
Settled enough: pick things back up, at the time you named. When you come back, start with one small, simple task, like putting the dishes away.

Next small action
Reply to my sister's message, one line

If you put it off: when you'll pick it back up
Tomorrow after lunch

☑ I'm going with this
Fill in your own: The Calm-Down Kit (Just me)

SCAN TO OPEN



WORKPAPER WP-11 · free to print
The Calm-Down Kit
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11



TOOL
Plan it once: handoff bag for two homes
spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting

06

Ask for support, as information.

Tell one person what you're trying and what would help. "I'm trying to walk after dinner. Would you ask me how it's going on Sunday?" They can say no, and you don't need anybody's permission to start anyway.

Since her husband's stroke, Glenys has done nearly all of his care, and for months she said "I'm fine" whenever her brother asked, until in the end she asked him something so specific that it would have been very hard to refuse. "Could you sit with him Thursdays, two till four, so I can swim?" He said yes before she'd finished, and he brings cookies. She's swum eleven Thursdays out of fourteen, which she thinks is pretty good.

07

Look back kindly once a month.

This is the monthly look-back from Book 4, Chapter 5 (page 97), pointed at yourself instead of a household. Ten minutes, once a month, asking what went well and what kept slipping. Was the gap in the plan, in what you had to give that month, or in one strange week? You don't add up old misses, because the only question is what to try next month. Its workpaper, What keeps coming back?, is written for a shared home, but the two questions work fine on your own.

Pauline is raising her two grandchildren. On the first of March she sat down with a pot of tea and a pen and saw, fairly quickly, that bedtime was working and homework very much wasn't, so in March homework moved to the kitchen table straight after a snack, before the TV went on. It worked for one child, and the other one, she says, is "a work in progress, like me."

SCAN TO OPEN



WORKPAPER WP-04 · free to print
What keeps coming back?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-04

08

Kindness to yourself is part of the plan.

There's an old image of the second arrow that I find useful here. The first arrow is the slip itself. The second is the scolding you give yourself afterward, which hurts more and helps less. A plan that needs you to be harsh with yourself is mostly second arrows. Rest belongs inside the plan, and you can shrink a goal or drop it whenever you like.

Harvey is sixteen, and he planned to study every night, missed three in a row, and announced at breakfast that he was useless and might as well not bother. His grandma went on buttering toast. "What would you tell Kian?" she said. Harvey rolled his eyes so hard it looked painful. That evening he did twenty minutes before dinner, and said nothing about it to anyone.

Three parts of being kind to yourself

Kristin Neff, who defined self-compassion for researchers, splits it into kindness instead of harsh judgment, remembering that everyone struggles instead of feeling alone with it, and noticing a painful feeling without being swallowed by it.

Neff (2003) · *Moderate: widely studied and promising; much of the research is correlational*

09

Set goals inside your circle, and spend energy where it comes back.

A goal that needs someone else to change is really a wish. You might wish your sister called more, but that's outside your circle. Calling her on the first Sunday of the month, and telling her you'd love her to call too, is inside it. Then treat your energy like the limited thing it is. Put more into the people and plans that give something back, and less into the ones that only take, so you've still got some left when you get near the goal.

THE FIRST OF THE MONTH

You open your notes app. Of the four small things you tried, two have stuck and two quietly stopped somewhere in the second week. You still don't know why the Saturday swim fell away. You liked the Saturday swim, as far as you can remember, so you put a question mark next to it and close the app.

TWO WAYS TO READ THIS

Small steps

BOTH DIRECTIONS Some minds find a fixed small routine restful, because once it's set, nothing needs deciding. Others find the same routine dull within a week and do better with a little variety built in. If you're the first kind, a friend who keeps changing the plan isn't being unreliable. Their brain is hunting for something new. If you're the second, the friend who wants it the same every time isn't being rigid. Sameness is how they save energy for everything else.

WHERE THE FIELDS MEET Behavioral science says habits beat good intentions, and that a routine too small to skip keeps going on the worst day. Finance adds a quieter idea, the reserve: small steps kept up become a margin you can draw on when a bad week comes.

You, in all your relationships

A goal for yourself nearly always brushes against other people, and small steps work everywhere. With a partner, offer one small habit instead of demanding one. With friends, one message a week can keep a friendship warm for years. In a family it might be a regular call, a visit you can actually keep up, or a first step after a long silence (see Reaching out, spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts). At work it could be one comment per meeting, and with money, one small saving habit that's yours alone.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 5

The self path, step by step

A person on their own, two weeks in

The path, step by step

Step	Where it's at
Check your battery	*Done ✓*

Step	Where it's at
Get to know your wiring	*Done ✓*
See where your lens came from	*Done ✓*
Plan what settles you	Not yet
Find words for what you feel	Not yet
Practice kind ways to say no	Not yet

Come back gently, once a week

Pick a day and a time, and add a ten-minute reminder to your own calendar. It repeats every week and just says "10 minutes for me."

Day	Time
Sunday	*7:30pm*

WHAT HAPPENS NEXT

The next step is Plan what settles you: the Calm-Down Kit. Three steps done is three steps done; the rest will still be here next week.

Fill in your own: The self path

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
Reaching out
spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts



ONLINE
The self path
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path

Common mix-ups

The commonest, and the least true, is that a goal has to be big to count. Small and repeatable is what survives a bad week, and most

big goals turn out to be a lot of small ones in a trench coat. Some people think that once they understand themselves they should be able to change anything. Wiring stays, though, so the aim is a goal that fits how you're built. Asking for support doesn't mean you couldn't manage, it just gives people what they need to help, and "I'll start on Monday" isn't always a dodge either. A fresh start can genuinely help, though the tiny version you could do today counts just as much.

> **A note on care:** This part is general education. It isn't therapy or coaching, and it can't promise any result. Nothing here is required, and nothing you write needs to be shared. If a goal ever starts to feel like a weight, you can shrink it or put it down.

If you want to start tonight, write your two words, one goal as something you'll do, the smallest first step you can think of and one if-then. Then put ten minutes in the calendar for a month from now. Your self-discovery path and Ten-minute start are free on the site.

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
Your self-discovery path
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path



TOOL
Ten-minute start
spreadloveandacceptance.com/start-in-10-minutes

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ Start with what matters to you.
- ✓ Name what gets in the way.
- ✓ Decide ahead with a simple if-then.
- ✓ Look back kindly once a month.
- ✓ Set goals inside your circle, and spend energy where it comes back.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 2, Chapter 7 · Values, meaning and a good life — Heal and Steady, page 117
Finding out what matters to you

Book 2, Chapter 6 · Habits and change — Heal and Steady, page 101
Why tiny steps and if-then plans work

Book 4, Chapter 5 · The monthly look-back — Share the Load, page 97
The same monthly look, done together

Chapter 5 · Self-worth, shame and self-compassion — page 79
A kinder inner voice when a step slips

PUT IT TO USE

The self path, step by step
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path

The Calm-Down Kit
Workpaper · free to print
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

Go deeper (free online) The expanded version of this chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-3-next-in-depth

4

BOOK 1 · CHAPTER 4

How feelings work: signals, the body, and naming what you feel

What feelings are for, where they start, and why putting a name to one can make it easier to carry, whether you're on your own, at home, with friends or at work.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. A feeling is a signal, not a verdict
2. Feelings start in the body
3. Naming a feeling helps you hold it
4. More words, better tools
5. Feelings come in layers
6. Feelings rise and pass like waves
7. Feelings spread between people
8. If you weren't brought up to talk about feelings
9. Feeling it isn't the same as doing it
10. In everyday life
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. More for your situation

THURSDAY, 4:50PM

A message from your manager. Have you got a minute tomorrow? No period, no smiley, nothing else at all.

By the time you get in you've snapped at the cat, decided you're not hungry, and gone back over every mistake of the past month, plus one from March that nobody else remembers. Nobody has said anything bad. You check the message again anyway, in case it's grown a period.

Feelings sit underneath nearly everything else in this book, so they get looked at first. Two tools elsewhere lean on this chapter. My weather today and the daily check-in (Chapter 2, page 25; Book 3, Chapter 1, page 7) ask for one word about how you are, because naming a feeling turns its volume down a little and a daily word catches feelings while they're still small. And Say it so it lands (Book 4, Chapter 4, page 73) asks you to describe a feeling, because "I felt let down" is a good deal easier to hear than "you never care."

Here is the knot in the stomach in quick strokes. On top, a short message from a manager. Under it, the body's alarm, which has already decided something is wrong. Under that, the meaning your mind gives the alarm. The roots are state and setting, and signal and noise. Then, slowly, each layer gets its own page or two.

01

A feeling is a signal, not a verdict.

Feelings are fast messages about what matters to you. Fear says watch out. Anger says this seems unfair, or this is in my way. Sadness says something that mattered has gone. A signal is worth listening to. It can also be badly wrong about the details, the way a smoke alarm goes off for burned toast with exactly the same urgency it would give a house fire.

Hayley's best friend has a new best friend, or that's how it feels, and Hayley is jealous and a bit ashamed of being jealous at thirty-four. The jealousy proves nothing about her, and nothing about whether the friend is drifting off either; it just shows how much the friendship matters, which is worth knowing, and possibly worth saying. "I'm being silly," she texts eventually, "but I miss you." The friend calls within the minute.

Sunny days and big questions

In a classic study, people phoned on sunny days rated their whole lives as more satisfying, and the bad-weather dip vanished once the interviewer mentioned the weather. Much bigger studies later found the weather effect itself is tiny. The useful part survives: spotting where a feeling comes from stops it coloring everything else.

Schwarz and Clore (1983) · *Moderate: a classic study of feelings as information; the weather effect proved very small*

THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF

"This feeling is telling me something matters. What is it?" "Is this the fire, or the toast?"

02

Feelings start in the body.

Often the body goes first. Racing heart, hot face, a weight on the chest, a knot in the stomach. Then the brain tries to work out what the signal means. It guesses, and it isn't always a good guesser. Which is why being hungry, or cold, or in pain, can feel so much like being upset.

Reece is fifteen and has come home in a fury about a towel. Specifically, about his mom asking where his gym towel was. There is a good deal of door involved. After a grilled cheese sandwich and twenty minutes on the couch with the dog's head on his knee, most of it has drained away, and he admits, through a mouthful, that he didn't have any lunch. "I wasn't hungry," he says. Then, "I was a bit hungry."

A few times today, stop and ask what your body feels like right now, and whether any of it is simply hunger, or cold, or a sore

back.

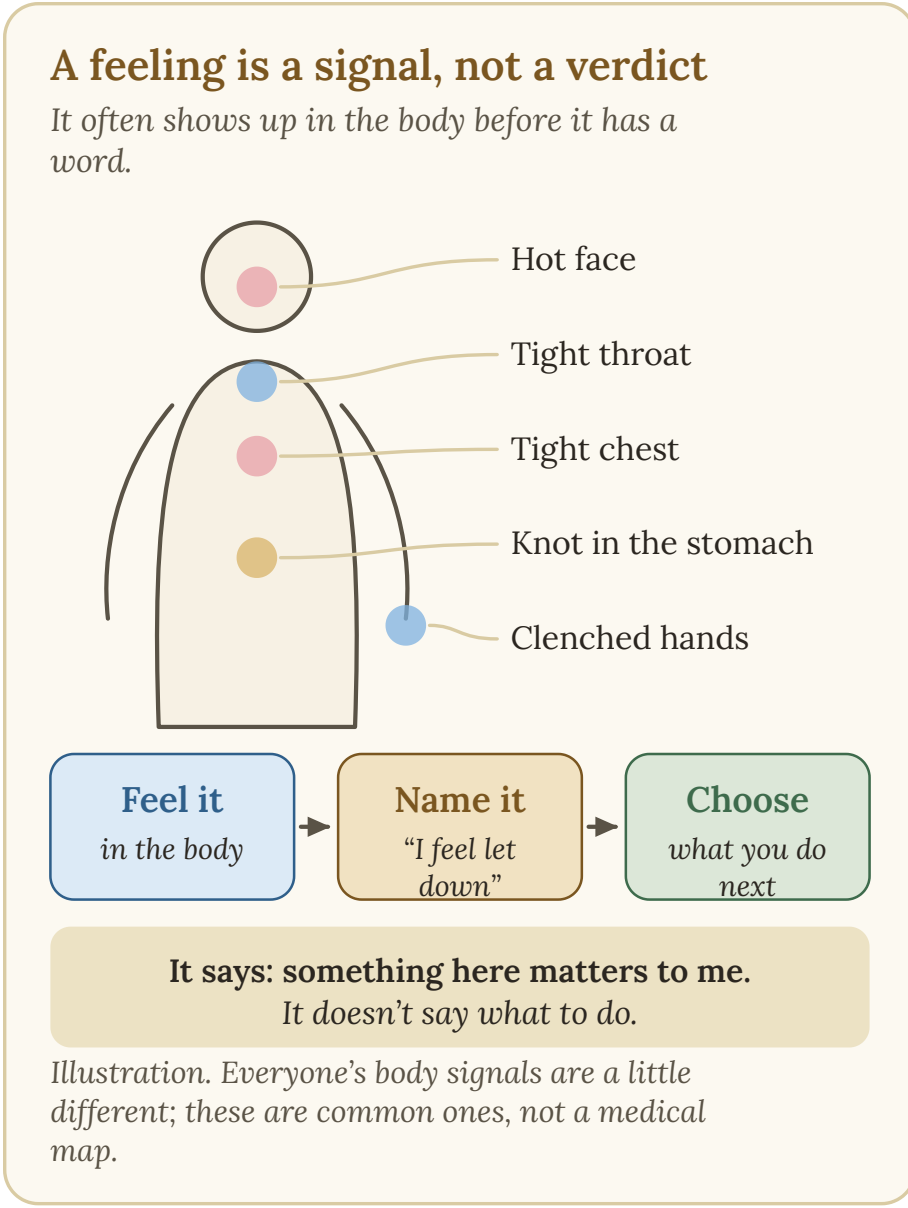


FIGURE 7 A feeling is a signal, not a verdict. It often shows up in the body first. Naming it helps you choose what to do next.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 6

My weather today

A 29-year-old at 4:50pm, after "Got a minute tomorrow?" from her manager

Check today's weather

The sky

Clear: Calm and connected · *Gusty: Revved up* · Fogged in: Running on empty

Who you'll mostly be around today

A partner · Family · A co-parent · Roommates · *Coworkers* · Someone I care for · Friends · Mostly on my own

The pressure

Light · *Building* · Heavy

Ground conditions

Haven't eaten in a while · Thirsty · In pain or unwell · Been still all day · Too much noise or light · *Running on caffeine* · Screens since I woke up

Last night's sleep

Barely slept · Short night · *About enough* · Properly rested

People load

Barely any · *A normal amount* · A lot · Nonstop, no gaps

What's blowing in

Work · Money · Kids or caring · Health · Family · The house · *One conversation* · Something I can't name

What would actually help in the next hour?

Space · Food or water · Rest · To move · *To be heard* · *A plan* · Company · Quiet · Someone to take something off me

YOUR FORECAST

Gusty today
Revved up · Some room today

Talk window
wait about 20 minutes

It's gusty. You're revved up. That energy is useful for doing something physical, but it is poor weather for deciding anything about another person.

The ground underneath: you haven't eaten in a while and you're running on caffeine. That isn't a side note. It's likely a big part of why today feels the way it does, and it's easier to change than character is.

Blowing in: one conversation. Weather from one front tends to land on whoever is nearest, often someone who had nothing to do with it. Worth saying out loud before it does.

You said what would help is a plan and to be heard. Arrange that before anything else.

If you want to send someone a line: "I don't need it solved. I just need you to hear this for a few minutes first."

Esme ate something, then talked it over with her sister to be heard. She didn't reply to the message until the morning.

Fill in your own: My weather today

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
My weather today
spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

03

Naming a feeling helps you hold it.

Putting a feeling into words can turn its volume down. In brain-scan research by Lieberman and colleagues (2007), simply putting a name to a feeling ("I feel scared") turned down the brain's alarm response. A name gives a big, cloudy rush some edges, so you can see it and talk about it and decide what to do.

Two roommates spent a whole evening passing each other in the hall without a word. Nobody had done anything, as far as either of them knew. At about ten, one of them stopped on the stairs. "I think I'm embarrassed about the noise complaint," she said, "and I've been taking it out on you by being weird." The other one, who had spent two hours going back over everything she'd said that week, laughed so hard she had to sit down. Then she made some tea.

It works even when it doesn't feel like it

A review by Torre and Lieberman found that naming a feeling can turn down its intensity even though, in the moment, it doesn't feel as if you're doing anything at all. So carry on with "something like sad" even when it seems pointless.

Torre and Lieberman (2018) · *Moderate: consistent lab evidence; how it works is still being worked out*

Once a day, name one feeling, out loud or on paper. A guess like "something like sad" counts.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

If the words won't come, weather words often will. "Foggy" or "stormy" is a perfectly good place to start.

TOOL **My weather today** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

04

More words, better tools.

"Bad" is a blunt instrument. Disappointed is different from left out, and both are different from overwhelmed or ashamed. Each one needs something different. A review by Kashdan, Barrett and McKnight (2015) found that people who can tell their feelings apart more finely tend to cope with them in healthier ways. You don't need a big vocabulary. A number does the job. So does a color.

Stephen told his partner he felt bad about his mom and they went around in circles for half an hour. Bad how? Bad about what? Then, out of nowhere, staring at the fridge: "I feel guilty I haven't been up since Easter. And I'm scared she's getting worse." Within ten minutes they were looking at trains to Pittsburgh, and the cheapest one turned out to leave at 6:12 in the morning, which led to a whole different conversation about who was going to drive them to the station.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
>
> "On a scale of one to ten, I'm about a six." "It's less angry and more… let down." "It feels heavy, like a gray day."

05

Feelings come in layers.

The feeling you show first isn't always the one you felt first. Anger very often sits on top of hurt or fear, because anger is a stronger place to stand. And we have feelings about our feelings (ashamed of being sad, mad about being scared) and that second layer can sting more than the first.

The visit has been canceled again. Brenda's daughter calls to say so, with a lot of reasons, all of them good ones, and Brenda says, "Fine. Well. Another time," in a voice like a closing door. Under that is hurt, and under the hurt, if she let herself look, there is a quieter

worry that she isn't needed much anymore by anyone, which is the one she has spent the last two years carefully not looking at. She doesn't look. She puts the phone down and sits next to it for a while with her coat still on.

Next time you're angry, you might ask whether there's hurt or worry underneath. You don't have to tell anyone what you find.

06

Feelings rise and pass like waves.

Most feelings, even big ones, rise and peak and settle, as long as you don't keep feeding them. Moods are something else. A mood is more like weather, a background feeling that hangs about for hours or days and colors everything without announcing itself.

By eleven o'clock on a Saturday morning Rachel had decided her whole life was going nowhere. In fairness it had been a morning. The water heater, a letter from the city, and a dream about her ex in which he was, for some reason, a dentist. By seven that evening, after a walk along the canal and an hour with her sister, the same life looked fairly ordinary and mostly all right, with an actual dentist on Tuesday and a library book she wanted to finish. Nothing in her life changed between eleven and seven.

Not every wave is the same length

Of 27 emotions in one study, sadness lasted longest, and shame, fear and disgust were among the shortest. The long ones tended to follow events that mattered, and to be chewed over.

Verduyn and Lavrijsen (2015) · *Moderate: a single self-report study, in line with other research on how long feelings last*

So if you can, leave big decisions until the wave has gone past. Write it down. Look at it tomorrow.

07

Feelings spread between people.

We catch each other's feelings from a tight voice, a sigh, a door shut slightly too hard, usually without noticing we've caught anything. It's part of how people bond. It also means stress can go around a house or a team like a cold in February.

Bryony came into the Monday meeting late and rattled, and within ten minutes six people who had been perfectly fine at nine o'clock felt behind on everything. The following Monday she stood outside the door for two slow breaths before going in. The meeting finished on time. In that office this was regarded as a minor miracle and nobody could work out why.

You can care about someone's feeling without catching the whole of it. Good moods are catching too, and Stay close has small ideas for passing one on. Notice who you tend to catch things from, and give yourself a minute before you next talk to them.

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
Stay close
spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding

08

If you weren't brought up to talk about feelings.

Lots of people grew up in homes, generations or cultures where feelings were kept private. "Don't make a fuss." "Big boys don't cry." "We don't talk about that." It's especially common among men and older people, and in some cultures keeping your feelings to yourself is a sign of respect and strength.

It isn't a flaw, and it doesn't mean you don't feel. Many people who rarely put a feeling into words show it every day by doing things, fixing the faucet or driving someone to the ER at two in the morning and waiting in the parking lot till it's over. They turn up. Caring by doing is real caring. Words can be added slowly, a few at a time, if you want them.

Len was a builder for forty years and his wife died in the spring. He has never in his life said how he feels about anything, apart from the Steelers. On the sideline at his grandson's game, during a long dull bit of the first half, he says to his son, "I wasn't brought up to say this. But I miss her. Every morning." His son puts a hand on his shoulder and leaves it there. Neither of them says anything else for the rest of the game. They watch the second half, which is also dull, and it's one of the better afternoons either of them has had all year.

> WAYS TO SAY IT
>
> "I wasn't brought up to say this, but I miss her." "I'm not good with words for this. It's been a hard week." "I don't know what to call it. I just feel heavy." "I'm not one for talking, but I wanted you to know I'm proud of you."

If one of those fits, you could say it once this week, to one person, or just out loud in the car. A text counts.

09

Feeling it isn't the same as doing it.

A feeling usually arrives with an urge attached, to shout or leave or hide or send the text you'll regret by dinnertime. You don't choose the feeling, but you get rather more say over the urge. Pushing a feeling down tends to bring it back bigger, and acting on every

urge hurts people, so the middle way is to let the feeling be there and choose the action.

A crash from the yard. Through the kitchen window, Imran's son is standing very still beside the greenhouse with a soccer ball, and there is a lot less greenhouse than there was. Imran feels the heat go up his neck. He opens the back door, says, "I'm too angry to talk about this. Ten minutes," shuts it again, and goes to find the dustpan. By the time he comes out his son has picked up most of the big bits, very carefully, in gardening gloves two sizes too large.

> FRIDAY, 9:05AM
>
> *The knot's back. This time you give it a name, which is scared, and then you do the thing you'd been avoiding and just ask. Your manager looks honestly baffled. "Oh God, no. It's the summer schedule." You go back to your desk and eat the breakfast you skipped, a banana that's been in your bag since Wednesday.*

TWO WAYS TO READ THIS

"I don't know how I feel"

FROM OUTSIDE Asked how they feel, someone says "I don't know" and seems stuck.

THE LOGIC Feelings start as signals in the body. Some people find those signals hard to read. With no clear signal there is no clear word. So "I don't know" is the honest answer.

IT'S LIKE A radio caught between two stations.

WHY IT FITS Finding feelings hard to name is common, and it is more common among autistic people.

THE OTHER SIDE The person asking may feel shut out, or think something is being hidden from them.

YOU COULD SAY *"I really don't know yet. Ask me about my body instead."*

ONE SMALL STEP Try simpler questions, such as "More tired or more tense?" and "Space or company?"

BOTH DIRECTIONS Some people feel first and find the words later, sometimes much later. Asked "What's wrong?" they honestly may not know yet. Others name a feeling almost as it arrives and expect everyone else to as well. If you name things fast, the quiet person may not be hiding anything. Their words are still on the way. If you need time, the quick namer may not be pushing. To them, saying it is how a feeling gets smaller.

WHERE THE FIELDS MEET Music has known for a long time that tone and tempo carry more than the words, and a feeling is often heard in the tune before the lyrics. Psychology adds that mood filters what we hear, so the same sentence lands differently on a bad day.

More situations like this one, each in the same six parts, are free online.
spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=dont-know-feeling

In everyday life

If you live on your own, nobody is going to notice how you are, so a one-word check-in with yourself each day matters more (see On my own, spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own). With a partner, "What are you feeling?" can sound like an exam. "Do you want to tell me, or shall I just sit with you?" is much easier to answer.

Children learn feeling words from the grown-ups near them, and hearing you say “I’m frustrated, so I’m going to take a breath” teaches more than any lesson. At work, “I’m a bit low today and I’m not upset with anyone” can stop a whole team guessing. And if someone close to you shows care by doing, like clearing the drive on your bad day, you can thank them for it in words. They may not know what to do with it the first time.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
On my own
spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own

Common mix-ups

Some feelings hurt and some actions do harm, but a feeling on its own isn’t bad. It’s information. Feeling stupid doesn’t make you stupid, either, so treat a feeling as something to check before you obey it. People also expect to know right away what they feel, and plenty can’t, some of them most days, which is why body words and numbers count as answers here. The most stubborn mix-up is the idea that a face tells you what someone feels. Faces are a poor guide. People show the same feeling in very different ways, and asking is kinder than guessing and a lot more accurate.

If you want to help someone else with this

Ask before you name it for them. “You’re angry” can land like a label. “You seem upset, am I reading that right?” leaves them room to put you straight. Then help the feeling make sense (“Of course

you're upset, that was a lot"), which does more than advice and doesn't mean you agree with everything they did. Ask whether they want ideas or just company. A lot of people only want the second and are relieved to be asked. Take other ways of saying it, a number or a text or "I'm at a seven." And settle yourself first. If their sadness makes you anxious, calm down before you go in, or they'll end up looking after you.

> YOU COULD SAY
>
> "That sounds really hard." "Do you want to talk, or would company help more?" "You don't have to find the right word. A number is fine."

Workpapers **pages you fill in, on your own or together**

- The Calm-Down Kit: a plan, made on a calm day, for heated moments.

SCAN TO OPEN

WORKPAPER WP-11 · free to print
The Calm-Down Kit
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

Tools **helpers you use on the website**

- My weather today: a short, private daily check of your mood and state.
- Upset right now?: steps for when a feeling is very big, very fast.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
My weather today
spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

TOOL
Cool-down corner: Upset right now?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

More for your situation

- Chapter 2: your wiring, your weather and your words (page 25)
- Wired differently and Neurodivergent relationships
- For teens: when feelings get loud
- For caregivers: resentment and guilt
- Grief and later life
- Help by relationship: find the pages for your situation.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Wired differently
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wired-differently

ONLINE
Neurodivergent relationships
spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships

ONLINE
For teens: when feelings get loud
spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens

ONLINE
For caregivers: resentment and guilt
spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers

ONLINE
Grief and later life
spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief

ONLINE
Help by relationship
spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **A feeling is a signal** that something matters to you. It doesn't tell you what to do about it.
- ✓ **Feelings start in the body.** A tight chest or a hot face often arrives before the word for it.
- ✓ **Naming helps.** "I feel let down" is easier to hold than a big, nameless rush.
- ✓ **You can let a feeling be there** and still choose what you do next.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Chapter 2 · Your wiring, weather and words — page 25
Reading your own weather day to day

Book 4, Chapter 3 · Full tanks and different angles — Share the Load, page 51
Feelings when a stress tank is full

Book 2, Chapter 1 · Stress and the nervous system — Heal and Steady, page 7
What the body does under pressure

Book 2, Chapter 2 · Anger — Heal and Steady, page 27
One feeling up close

PUT IT TO USE



The Calm-Down Kit

Workpaper · free to print: A plan, made on a calm day, for heated moments

spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11



My weather today

A short, private daily check of your mood and state

spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks



Go deeper (free online) The expanded version of this chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try:

spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-1-feelings-in-depth

5

BOOK 1 · CHAPTER 5

Self-worth, shame and self-compassion

Why your worth isn't a score you keep earning, how shame differs from guilt, and why being kind to yourself makes it easier to grow.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Your worth isn't a score
2. Guilt says "I did a bad thing." Shame says "I am bad."
3. Shame makes you want to hide
4. The inner critic is trying to protect you
5. Self-compassion isn't letting yourself off
6. Comparing yourself pulls your worth outside you
7. You can own a mistake without drowning in it
8. Worth is learned between people, and we can give it
9. In everyday life
10. Feedback, criticism and put-downs are three different things
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. More for your situation

THURSDAY, 11:20PM

You sent the wrong spreadsheet to the whole team. Last quarter's, not this one's. Priyanka spotted it in four minutes, sent the right one and added "no worries!!" with two exclamation marks, which somehow made it worse.

It's nearly midnight. The file stopped being the point some time around ten. The voice has moved on to bigger things now, like how you've always been a bit useless, really, and now they all know.

This chapter is about how self-worth and shame work, and then about what you can actually do with them. None of it is a diagnosis. Take what helps.

A wrong spreadsheet, read quickly, has layers. On the surface, a file sent to the whole team. Underneath, guilt about the file, which is useful. Underneath that, shame about yourself, which isn't. The roots are signal and noise, what the mistake really says, and balance. The chapter slows down on the second and third layers.

01

Your worth isn't a score.

A lot of us carry a quiet scoreboard, on which we're worth something when we're useful, or liked, or slim, or busy, or top of the class, or never any bother to anybody. Psychologists call these "conditions of worth," and the trouble with a score is that it can drop. If your worth goes up and down with each day's results, then every bad day is a verdict.

Pam taught third grade for forty years. In the September after she retired she found herself in the supermarket at ten on a Tuesday morning, holding a basket with nothing in it, feeling lost in a way she couldn't have explained to anyone. Nothing was wrong. But for four decades being needed was how she knew she mattered, and the bell had stopped ringing.

Try finishing "I feel okay about myself when I…" three times, then look at what you wrote. Those are your scores. Just noticing them is enough for now.

02

Guilt says "I did a bad thing." Shame says "I am bad."

Guilt is about something you did, so it points somewhere useful. Say sorry. Put it right. Shame is about who you are, which feels impossible to fix, and so it makes people hide, or freeze, or blame

someone else, or lash out. Research on the two feelings, such as June Tangney and Ronda Dearing's (2002), suggests guilt is the one more likely to lead to repair.

Rhys is twelve and he has just knocked his mom's favorite mug off the counter, the one with the hare on it that she bought on the boardwalk in Cape May years ago and drinks her first tea of the day from, and there are two ways this can go. Guilt says go and tell her, and maybe offer some birthday money. Shame says you ruin everything, and this time shame wins. He wraps the pieces in yesterday's paper and pushes them right down to the bottom of the trash can, under the potato peelings, where his mom finds them on Sunday.

It was the hiding that upset her. She told him so. It took him a while to see what she meant.

03

Shame makes you want to hide.

You feel shame in the body before you think it. Hot face, eyes down, stomach dropping, a strong wish for the floor to open. It also comes out sideways, as sudden anger or a closed, cold face, which is how a small comment turns into a big fight.

"Didn't we already cover this?" It was a mild question, asked in a Tuesday meeting by a man who genuinely couldn't remember. Becky snapped at him, properly, in front of nine people. That evening, scraping a plate into the trash, she worked out that it had nothing to do with him. She'd felt stupid in front of everyone, and stupid had come out as sharp.

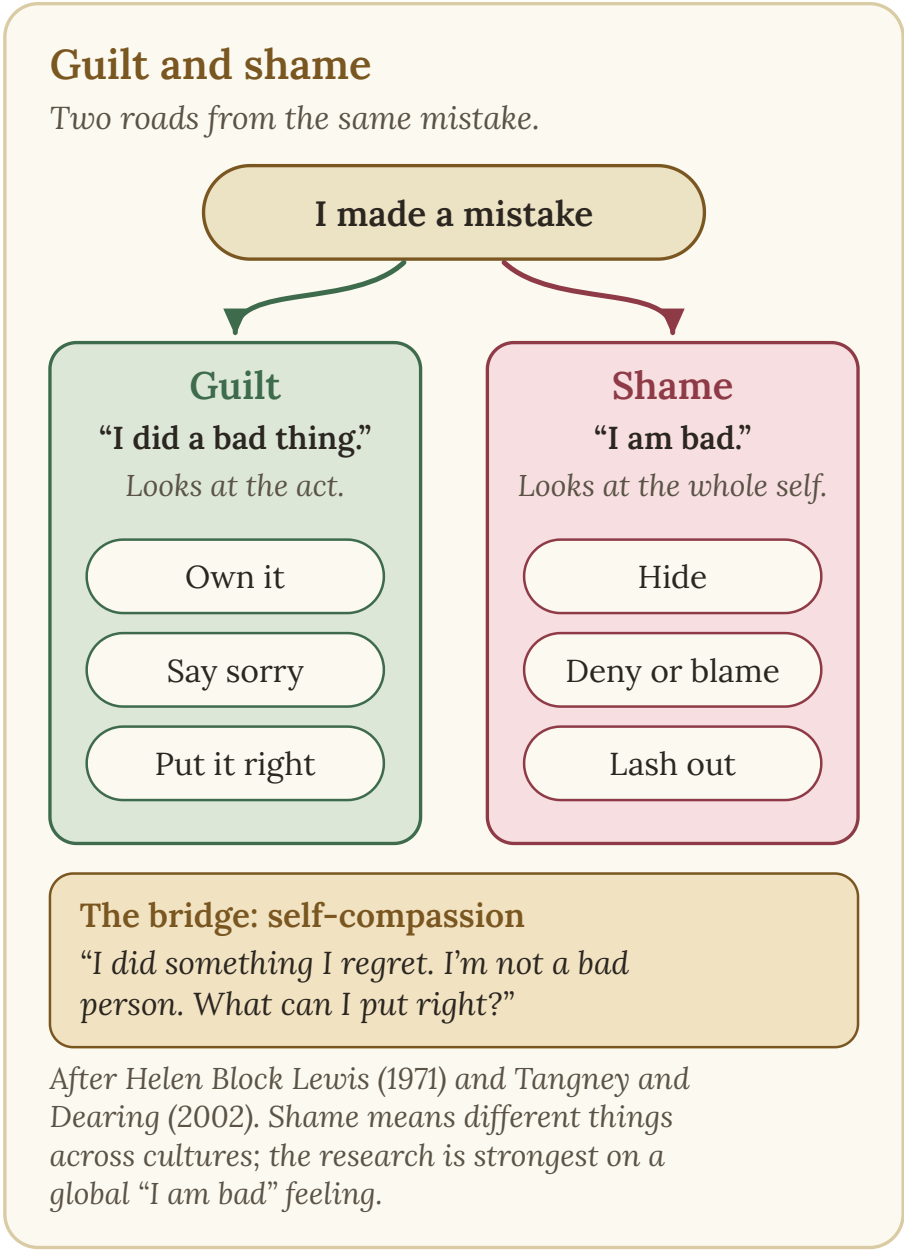


FIGURE 8 Guilt says "I did a bad thing." Shame says "I am bad." Guilt is easier to put right, and self-compassion helps you cross over.

Learn your own signs, if you can. Next time you suddenly want to vanish, or bite, you can name it quietly to yourself, and now and

then out loud. “Sorry, I think I felt embarrassed and it came out sharp. Can I try that again?”

04

The inner critic is trying to protect you.

That harsh inner voice usually started as protection. If you criticize yourself first, perhaps nobody else gets the chance. If you’re hard enough on yourself, perhaps you’ll never fail again. It meant well, in its way. But a voice that only threatens keeps your body on alert, and it’s exhausting to share a head with.

Every time Craig forgets something for the baby he calls himself an idiot. Out loud, sometimes. The wipes. The rabbit she won’t sleep without. It’s the word his own dad used about him, all through his childhood. Patting his pockets in the daycare parking lot for a rabbit that’s on the kitchen table, he hears it in his dad’s voice, exactly, and it strikes him as odd that he’s still using it.

Perfectionism has been creeping up

Students’ perfectionism scores rose between 1989 and 2016, according to a meta-analysis by Curran and Hill, with the sharpest rise in the feeling that other people expect you to be perfect. It’s questionnaire data from Western countries and it can’t say why, but if that feeling is loud for you, you have company.

Curran and Hill (2019) · *Moderate: questionnaire data from Western countries; does not explain the cause*

Write down one thing your critic says a lot. Would you say it to a friend you loved? Some people find it helps to answer the critic directly. “Thanks. I know you’re trying to protect me. I can take it from here.”

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 7

Flip it

A 44-year-old after a mistake at work

Flip it

What's on your mind?

I got the figures wrong in the client report and my manager had to fix it. I'm hopeless at this job.

What kind is it?

A complaint about someone · A worry · *Being hard on myself* · Anger

THE FLIP

What a good friend might say

"That sounds like a hard moment. One mistake is not the whole of you. You're not hopeless. You're a person having a hard day."

Kinder words for yourself

"I had a hard moment. I'm human. Next time I'll check the totals once before I send."

One next step

A reminder on my phone to check the totals before I send, set tonight.

Talking to yourself the way you'd talk to a friend is a simple form of self-compassion. Being harsh rarely makes the next try easier. This is a starting point. Change any words you like.

Their own words, after changing the flip

I got two figures wrong and it was caught before the client saw it. I'm human. Next time I'll ask a colleague to check the numbers before it goes out.

His next step

Send my manager a two-line sorry and the checking plan, today, then go home on time.

The flip is a starting point: Hamish changed the words until they were true and sounded like him.

Fill in your own: Flip it

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL

Small wins: Flip it

spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins

05

Self-compassion isn't letting yourself off.

Self-compassion means treating yourself the way you'd treat a good friend who's having a rotten time. One well-known model has three parts. Kindness instead of attack. Remembering that everyone struggles. Noticing the pain without drowning in it. Studies, such as one by Juliana Breines and Serena Chen (2012), suggest that people who are kind to themselves after a failure are often *more* likely to try to improve.

Lindy failed her driving test for the third time, on the reverse around a corner again, clipping the same curb she had clipped in March, and afterward she sat in the DMV parking lot for a while with the engine off. Then she told herself what she'd have told her sister, more or less. This is hard. Lots of people need more tries. You're fine everywhere except that one corner. On Sunday morning she was on the empty industrial park by the beltway with

her dad in the passenger seat, backing around the same lamp post eleven times.

If it feels all right, try putting a hand on your arm once today and saying, slowly, “This is a hard moment. Other people feel this too. What do I need?” It will feel silly the first time, and probably the second.



SUGARFOOT

Speak to yourself the way you’d speak to a friend having a hard day, slowly and kindly. Writing it down first helps.

TOOL **Write it through** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/write-it-through

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Write it through
spreadloveandacceptance.
com/write-it-through

06

Comparing yourself pulls your worth outside you.

Everyone measures themselves against other people. It’s how we work out where we stand. But a feed full of other people’s best moments makes the measuring wildly unfair, and self-esteem that depends on being better than others swings about all over the place.

Two old friends met for a curry, one of them having just bought a house. The other rents a room in a shared apartment in Queens where the shower only works if you hold it. The renter spent the whole evening quietly ranking herself, and she missed what was right in front of her. Her friend was lonely in the new house, and

had wanted to say so all evening, and kept waiting for a gap in the conversation that never came because the renter was so busy ranking herself. You're comparing your inside with somebody's outside. When you catch yourself at it, try a question instead. "How are you, really?"

Why we compare at all

Leon Festinger proposed in 1954 that people judge their opinions and abilities by comparing themselves with others, especially when there's no objective standard to go by. Worth has no objective standard, which may be exactly why comparing goes so badly there.

Festinger (1954) · *Strong: a foundational theory with a large body of later research*

07

You can own a mistake without drowning in it.

Owning a mistake gets a lot easier once it doesn't mean you're worthless. Say what you did. Say what it did to the other person. Say what you'll do now. Then stop. Beating yourself up afterward proves nothing about how sorry you are, it just pulls everyone's attention back onto you.

Jess forgot to pay her share of the internet bill and it got cut off for the whole long weekend. On Tuesday, after a weekend of the others tethering their laptops to their phones and one of them going to the library to finish an essay, she stuck her head in the living room door. "I forgot to pay, and it left you all without internet for three days. I've paid it and set a reminder for the 28th." Someone said "Thanks," and that was more or less the end of it.

If it went wrong in a conversation, Rewind the talk helps you find the words. Then decide whether to send them or let it rest.

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
Rewind the talk
spreadloveandacceptance.
com/carrier-wave-decoder

08

Worth is learned between people, and we can give it.

Children learn their worth from how they're treated, and adults never entirely stop. The words matter, because "You did a careless thing" leaves room to change, while "You're so careless" shuts the door. Notice effort, and who someone is, as well as results, and people feel they matter on bad days too.

Gill took over a team that hid its problems until week ten, and from her first month she started every project review with the same question, "What did we learn?" and refused, politely and repeatedly, to discuss who had gotten what wrong. Within six months people were bringing problems to her in week two, which saved everyone a great many Friday evenings, and the sappy question stayed.

Today you could say one thing to someone that has nothing to do with how well they've done. Even just "I'm glad I know you."

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can't control how other people judge you, or what you were taught about your worth growing up. You can control how you speak to yourself now, whether you repair what you can, and where you spend your time. Give your energy to people who treat you as someone who matters. More in Your wiring, weather and words (Chapter 2, page 25)

FRIDAY, 9:15AM

You send one line. Sorry about the mix-up with yesterday's file, right one attached. When the voice starts up again you try answering it the way you would a friend. You got it wrong and you fixed it, which is what a decent colleague does. The voice is not convinced. Priyanka sends a thumbs-up, and by lunch you've mostly stopped thinking about it.

TWO WAYS TO READ THIS

Saying sorry all the time

FROM OUTSIDE Someone apologizes for asking a question, for being in the way, for taking up room.

THE LOGIC An early apology can head off someone else's anger. The habit was often learned long ago, somewhere it kept things calm. The sorry works like a shield. So it is often about safety more than guilt.

IT'S LIKE Ducking before anything has been thrown.

WHY IT FITS The habit made sense where it was learned, even if today is safe.

THE OTHER SIDE Constant apologies can sound hollow, or make the listener feel they must have been harsh.

YOU COULD SAY *"Sorry is an old habit of mine. I'm learning I don't need it here."*

ONE SMALL STEP Swap one sorry a day for a thank you. "Thanks for waiting" works where "Sorry I'm late" used to.

BOTH DIRECTIONS For some people a correction is just information: "slide four has a typo" means slide four has a typo. For others, the same sentence lands as a verdict on them, often because a lot of earlier corrections were. If you're the first kind, it can help to say the plain part plainly and add one warm sentence. If you're the second, it can help to ask, "Is this about the slide, or about me?" Usually it really is the slide.

WHERE THE FIELDS MEET The art of debating has a rule that fits this chapter well: separate the claim from the person. "I did a bad thing" is a claim about an act. Laughter, used gently, can help too, laughing with yourself and never at yourself. The research on laughter is young and modest, so treat that as a small help.

More situations like this one, each in the same six parts, are free online.
spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=sorry-a-lot

In everyday life

Shame turns up in very ordinary places. Between partners, "You forgot to call" can land as "You're a terrible partner," so what comes

back is a defense instead of a sorry. A child who hears "You're so naughty" learns something about who they are, while "That was a naughty thing to do" leaves a way back. A friend who says yes to everything may be quietly burning out, because no feels like risking being dropped. At work, someone may sit on a small error for weeks because owning it feels like proof they never belonged there.

On your own: a kinder voice to keep

You don't need anyone else for this. Notice how you talk to yourself and practice one gentler sentence. Catch the critic's favorite words ("always," "useless," "pathetic," "should") and swap one for a plain fact. "I'm hopeless" becomes "I was late twice this week." On bad days, keep a short list of what you did, and let getting up count. You're allowed to be disappointed in what you did and still be on your own side.

Feedback, criticism and put-downs are three different things.

Feedback is about something you did and what would work better, and it usually comes with a reason. Criticism aims at you as a person ("You always…," "You never…"). It's common in tired, stressed moments. In couples studied by Gottman (1994), criticism went with more unhappiness later, while a plain complaint about one specific thing did not. A put-down is something else again, and it's worth being exact about it, because the label hurts if it's wrong.

For something to be a put-down, these are usually all present:

- it's about who you are, not one thing you did,
- it keeps happening over weeks or months,
- it carries on after the thing is fixed or explained,

- it often lands in front of other people or on what you care about most.

Not enough on its own:

- one sharp comment on a bad day,
- plain words without padding, or a family where everyone talks bluntly,
- a fair complaint that came out badly,
- teasing that both of you enjoy and either of you can stop.

If you raise it, describe what was said and how it landed, and leave the label out. “When you called me useless in front of your sister, I felt small. What was really bothering you?” gives the other person something to answer.

Common mix-ups

People worry that self-compassion is just self-pity. They feel quite different from the inside. Self-pity says “only me, poor me.” Self-compassion says “this is hard, and other people go through it too,” which joins you to other people instead of shutting you away from them. Others fear that being kind to themselves will make them lazy. The research leans the other way, because it’s fear of your own attack that makes people stop trying and hide their mistakes. And self-worth doesn’t mean thinking you’re great, only that you go on mattering on the days when you plainly aren’t.

If you want to help someone else with this

Talk about what happened, never about what sort of person they are. Arguing with someone’s shame (“You’re not useless!”) can feel like being told they’re wrong to feel it, so you might try “It sounds

like you feel really low about it. I don't see you that way." Helping them find one small thing they can do gives the feeling somewhere to go. And kindness on ordinary days, when nothing has gone wrong, teaches worth far better than anything said in a crisis.

> YOU COULD SAY
>
> "That sounds like it's weighing on you. Want to work out one thing that would help?" "You don't have to earn being cared about."

Tools helpers you use on the website

- Upset right now? for a feeling that is too big to think through
- Ask Professor Puddles, the site's chat host, to help you find a kinder sentence

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Cool-down corner: Upset right now?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

TOOL
Ask Professor Puddles
spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask

More for your situation

- **On your own:** Chapter 1: where you came from (page 7) · Your self-discovery path · On my own after a breakup
- **Teens:** For teens: feelings
- **Neurodivergent:** Wired differently · Neurodivergent relationships
- **At work:** At work
- **Coming out:** Coming out as an adult

- **Caregivers and parents:** Caring for someone you love · When a child has ADHD
- **Related chapters:** Loss, grief and big life changes (Book 2, Chapter 4, page 65) · Minds that work differently (Chapter 7, page 115)

Find your own starting point: Help by relationship.

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
Your self-discovery path
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path



ONLINE
On my own after a breakup
spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own



ONLINE
For teens: feelings
spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens



ONLINE
Wired differently
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wired-differently



ONLINE
Neurodivergent relationships
spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships



TOOL
Team job list: the 10-minute weekly round
spreadloveandacceptance.com/work



ONLINE
Coming out as an adult
spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-out



ONLINE
Caring for someone you love
spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers



ONLINE
When a child has ADHD
spreadloveandacceptance.com/adhd-kids



ONLINE
Help by relationship
spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ Your worth isn't a score.
- ✓ Shame makes you want to hide.
- ✓ Self-compassion isn't letting yourself off.
- ✓ Comparing yourself pulls your worth outside you.
- ✓ Worth is learned between people, and we can give it.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Chapter 1 · Where your lens came from page 7
Old rules that taught you your worth

Chapter 3 · Who you are becoming page 45
Kindness when a goal slips

Book 2, Chapter 5 · Healing after hurt Heal and Steady, page 81
Guilt, apology and forgiveness

Book 2, Chapter 3 · Worry, low mood and trauma Heal and Steady, page 45
When the inner critic gets loud

PUT IT TO USE

Cool-down corner: Upset right now?
For a feeling that is too big to think through
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

Ask Professor Puddles
The site's chat host, to help you find a kinder sentence
spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask

Go deeper (free online) The expanded version of this chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-7-worth-in-depth

6

BOOK 1 · CHAPTER 6

Personality, temperament and change across life

What personality is, where temperament comes in, how people change across their lives, and how to live and work with people who are made differently from you, without putting anyone in a box.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Traits work like dials
2. Temperament is the starting point
3. Situations matter too
4. Introvert and extravert is about energy, not liking people
5. People change across life
6. You can change on purpose, a little at a time
7. Every trait has gifts and costs
8. Differences are usually about fit
9. In everyday life
10. Narcissistic, toxic and other labels people reach for
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. More for your situation

AT A GLANCE

- **Traits work like dials.** Everyone sits somewhere along each one, and most people are near the middle.
- **Temperament is a starting point.** Babies already differ in how active, cautious or easily upset they are, and what happens next matters too.
- **People keep changing.** On average people grow steadier and more organized as they get older, and you can change on purpose, slowly.

- **Most clashes between personalities are about fit**, and nobody has to be at fault.

SATURDAY, 3:00PM

Your aunt's seventieth, in the party room above the golf club. You're standing by the cake, minding your own business, when she tells the whole room, "Oh, she was always the shy one!"

Everybody laughs, and you laugh along with them, and something stings.

You're forty-two. Every weekday at 8:40 you stand in front of thirty eight-year-olds and get them to sit down, which takes some doing. So are you still the shy one? Were you ever?

We describe each other by personality all the time, as laid-back, or a worrier, or the organized one, and descriptions like those have a way of setting hard. This chapter is about how personality actually works, what stays put and what moves. Two tools elsewhere build on it. The "How to talk to me" card and the style quiz (Chapter 2, page 25) describe how you lean on a few dials, which is more use than knowing which box somebody once put you in. And One owner per job (Book 4, Chapter 2, page 27) arranges the jobs around people's differences, so nobody has to turn into someone else to share a house.

Quickly, one "difficult" colleague has three layers. On the surface, behavior you don't like. Underneath, a trait, a dial set differently from yours. Underneath that, a situation that suits one setting and not the other. The roots are limited capacity and ownership and structure. Slowly now, dial by dial.

01

Traits work like dials.

Personality is the usual pattern in how you think and feel and act. Many psychologists describe it with five broad traits, often called the "Big Five": **openness** (curious about new ideas and experiences), **conscientiousness** (organized and careful), **extraversion** (drawn to people and busy places), **agreeableness** (warm and cooperative) and **emotional stability** (how steady your moods are).

The same five turned up in work such as McCrae and Costa (1987), whether people rated themselves or were rated by people who knew them well. Each runs from low to high, and most people sit near the middle of most of them. That's the bit online quizzes leave out. Two friends did one on the train to Santa Cruz and were told, very confidently, that one was an introvert and the other an extravert. Then they looked at the actual numbers. Four points apart, both right in the middle. They spent the rest of the journey arguing about which of them was more middle.

If you're curious, mark where you think you sit on each dial from one to ten, and ask a close friend where they'd put you. The gap is often the interesting bit.

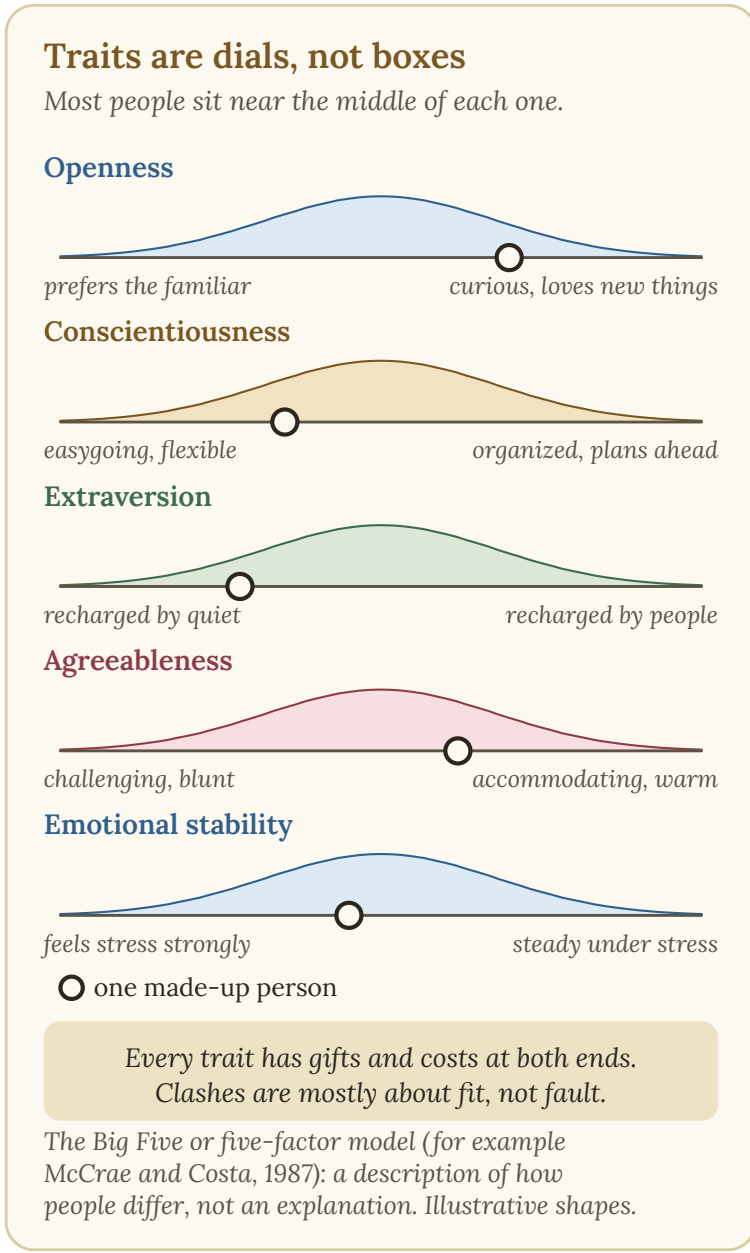


FIGURE 9 Traits work like dials, and most people sit near the middle of each. Illustrative shapes.

02

Temperament is the starting point.

Temperament is the part of personality you can see very early on. Some babies are on the go from the moment they wake. Some are calm. Some take to a new routine right away and some need a week. Some flinch at every loud noise. In their long-running study, Thomas and Chess (1977) described these early differences and the idea of "goodness of fit," meaning how well a child's temperament suits what the people and places around them expect.

Isla is two and cried at every new preschool group. Her mom tried coaxing her into the circle, then bribing her, then (once, quietly) begging. In the end she just sat at the edge of the church basement with Isla on her lap, feeling a bit silly, while everyone else did "The Wheels on the Bus." It smelled of orange drink and floor wax. Week three, Isla climbed down on her own, walked to the sand table, and didn't look back. Her mom, slightly put out, had a cookie.

Sensitive isn't the same as shy

Elaine and Arthur Aron described a trait they called sensory-processing sensitivity, taking things in deeply, and found it was partly separate from introversion. Researchers still argue about its exact shape. Still, the child hanging back may be taking everything in rather than shrinking from it.

Aron and Aron (1997) · *Moderate: a widely used measure; the trait's structure is still debated*

YOU COULD SAY

"You like to watch first. That's fine. Join in when you're ready." (to yourself) "I need time to warm up. That's how I'm made."

03

Situations matter too.

Personality describes a pattern, and patterns have exceptions. The same person can be loud with family and quiet at work, endlessly patient with toddlers and very short with call centers. A trait tells

you what someone tends to do across lots of situations and a good deal less about the one in front of you.

Anita had decided her new colleague was cold. Polite, competent, cold. Then came the fundraiser soccer game, and there he was in a borrowed bib two sizes too small, shouting encouragement at a goalkeeper who was letting in everything. On Monday Anita sat looking around the open-plan office with its gray partitions and humming lights and wondered how much of what she'd seen was the room.

04

Introvert and extravert is about energy, not liking people.

People who are more introverted often like people a lot. What they find is that busy, noisy company uses energy up, and they need quiet afterward to get it back. People who are more extraverted tend to be topped up by company. Most of us are a mix (sometimes called an ambivert), and every point on the dial just needs different things to be at its best.

> **Happy now, tired later**
> Forty-eight people tracked for twelve days felt better while acting outgoing and more tired about three hours later, introverts and extraverts alike. It's a small study, and the authors say so.
>
> **Leikas and Ilmarinen (2017)** · *Early: a small study (48 people); the authors asked for it to be repeated*

Eleven o'clock at a wedding in a barn outside Asheville. Fraser wants the after-party in the local bar. Luke wants bed and silence and possibly never to hear "Mr. Brightside" again. They've had this exact standoff at four previous weddings. This time Fraser goes for an hour and Luke walks back to the hotel along the lane with his shoes in his hand, and they meet at breakfast, one of them hoarse and the other one smug, both of them happy. What Luke said, for once, was "I loved

tonight, and I'm out of social energy," which he'd practiced on the walk from the car.

05

People change across life.

Personality is fairly stable. It also moves. A large review by Roberts, Walton and Viechtbauer (2006) found that, on average, people become more organized, more emotionally steady and more confident with others as they move through adult life, with much of the change between 20 and 40. A later review by Bleidorn and colleagues (2022) found that emotional steadiness went on growing right across the lifespan. Big life events play a part, and so do the roles people take on and who they love.

At school Tunde lost his keys about once every two weeks and once turned up to a math exam on the wrong day. He's a charge nurse now, forty-six, the calm one people look for when it goes wrong at three in the morning. At the reunion his old friends kept staring at him from across the banquet room, and eventually one of them came over with two beers and said, "What happened to you?" He thought about it. "Life kept asking me to cope," he said, "and eventually I learned how."

06

You can change on purpose, a little at a time.

If you want to change a trait you can, slowly, mostly by acting differently in small ways over and over. In a study by Hudson and Fraley (2015), people who set goals to change one of their traits tended to move in the direction they wanted over sixteen weeks. A review by Roberts and colleagues (2017) found that therapy was often linked to lasting change too, especially toward more emotional steadiness.

Noor wanted to be less quiet at work. She made a rule. One thing in every team meeting, even if it was only "I agree with Neil." The first two weeks her heart thudded so hard she was sure people could see it through her sweater. By the end of the second month it had become ordinary, and somewhere in the third month she forgot it had ever been a rule. Pick one small thing that fits who you'd like to be more of, and do it three times this week. Book 2, Chapter 6 (page 101) has more on habits.

07

Every trait has gifts and costs.

There's no good personality. Every trait helps in some places and gets in the way in others. Very agreeable people are lovely to be around and may find "no" almost impossible to say. Very conscientious people are the ones you'd leave your keys with, and they can't always stop. People high in openness love anything new and can be bored to tears by routine.

For most of a year Alys was irritated by her roommate. His sneakers in the hall. His "it'll be fine." Then the water heater died on the coldest night in January, and while Alys stood in the kitchen in her coat reading the manual, he called around until he found a plumber who'd come out at ten o'clock, and then he heated soup on the stove and passed around every blanket in the apartment. "It'll be fine," he said, and it was, apart from the pot that boiled over.

A one-page card, "How to talk to me," turns a trait people complain about into plain information about what helps.

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
How you connect: how I like to be spoken to
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card

08

Differences are usually about fit.

When two people with different personalities share a home or a family or a job, friction is normal. A tidy person and a relaxed one can both be right in their own way, and so can a planner and someone spontaneous, or a talker and someone who needs quiet. What helps is naming the difference and agreeing how to live with it, without either of you being the problem. Personality is also different from neurodivergence and from mental health conditions. If something feels bigger than personality, Chapter 7 (page 115) may help.

A couple argues about every single vacation, because one wants every hour planned and the other wants to wander about and see what happens. This year they plan the mornings and leave the afternoons free, and they still argue about the mornings. I'd count that as progress.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 8

How you connect: the style quiz

A person before moving in with a friend

The style quiz: just my Wave Code

Twelve quick either/or taps, about two minutes.

Your first name (optional)

Mo

Someone asks you a big question. You…

Answer right away and figure it out as I talk

Need a moment, or a day, to think first

A sudden change of plans feels…

Fine, maybe even fun Jarring. I need a heads-up or a transition

Starting something new, you want…

The why and the big vision The first concrete step

When something bothers you, you usually…

Say it plainly so we can fix it *Hint at it, or wait for the right moment*

Someone says "I'm fine." You…

Believe them. Fine means fine *Check their tone to see if they really are*

…and seven more like these.

FOUR LEANINGS (WAVE CODE: S F N A)

What each letter means

Pace: leans Slow Simmer (S, not Quick Spark) · Lens: leans Forest (F, not Trees) · Sending: leans Nuanced (N, not Direct) · Receiving: strongly Attuned (A, not Explicit)

The nickname the tool gives it: the Willow

Reflective and soft-spoken. Feels the undercurrents of every room.

Watch for

agreeing in the moment just to fill the silence; your real needs getting lost in the cushioning.

Mo's style-quiz statement: "About how I'm wired: I think first and talk second, I tend to hint rather than say it straight, I see the big picture first, and I like to take my time."

A Wave Code is shorthand for four preferences, each a lean along a dial, not a type or a box. "Leans" means near the middle. Answers can change with the day, the setting and the person you're with.

Fill in your own: How you connect

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL

How you connect: the 2-minute style quiz

spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can get to know your own mix, look after what you need, and practice one small change if you want to. You can't change someone else's personality, and you don't have to change yours to be loved. If you're always the one bending to fit, it's fair to say so. More in Know your own wiring, free online.

SATURDAY, 5:30PM

People are drifting off with slices of cake in paper towels. You think about sitting down next to your aunt and telling her about the thirty eight-year-olds. You don't. You help stack the plates. On the drive home you're still turning it over, half annoyed with her and half with yourself, and somewhere around the beltway you start drafting what you'll say at Christmas if she does it again. It's quite a good line.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Know your own wiring
spreadloveandacceptance.com/know-yourself

TWO WAYS TO READ THIS

Eating the same lunch every day

FROM OUTSIDE The same sandwich, every day, for years.

THE LOGIC Every new food is a small gamble. A known food is a sure thing. Sure things save energy for the rest of the day. So sameness is a way of being efficient.

IT'S LIKE A pilot's checklist, the same each time on purpose.

WHY IT FITS For people with strong senses of taste and texture, a known food takes away an unpleasant surprise.

THE OTHER SIDE The cook may feel their food is being turned down.

YOU COULD SAY *"It's safe and easy for me. It says nothing about your cooking."*

ONE SMALL STEP Keep one safe option on the table beside anything new.

BOTH DIRECTIONS For some people a new lunch is a small pleasure, and the same sandwich every day sounds dull. For others every new food is a small gamble on taste, texture and how it sits, and a known lunch is one decision they never have to make. If you like variety, the same-lunch person isn't stuck. They're saving their energy for the rest of the day. If you like sameness, the variety person isn't restless. Trying something new is part of what makes lunch a break for them.

WHERE THE FIELDS MEET Economics treats attention as a budget, and personality is partly about where the budget goes and how fast it runs out. Business has a related habit: match each job to the person whose strengths suit it, and give it one owner, so nobody has to pretend to be someone else to get it done.

More situations like this one, each in the same six parts, are free online.
spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=same-food

In everyday life

On your own

Knowing your own mix helps you build a life that suits you, with about the right amount of company and quiet. "I'm just not a people person" might be true. It might also be an old label that deserves testing at least once. With a partner, a shared plan (one

does the bills, the other does vacations) usually goes better than trying to change each other. A quiet friend who hardly texts may still care a great deal, so ask what kind of contact suits them. A child's temperament says nothing about good or bad parenting, and adjusting to fit them is a skill you pick up. And family roles like "the clever one" or "the difficult one" can hang on long after they stop fitting. You're allowed to grow out of them, whether or not your aunt has noticed.

Narcissistic, toxic and other labels people reach for.

Words from clinics have drifted into everyday arguments. Narcissistic personality disorder is a clinical diagnosis, and a diagnosis is a complicated judgment that a short chapter, a test or a stranger on the internet can't make. It describes a long-lasting pattern across most of a person's life, not a bad week or a bad breakup. "Toxic" isn't a clinical word at all.

For something to be a personality pattern of this kind, these are usually all present:

- it shows up across many years and most settings, at home, at work and with friends,
- it includes a constant need for admiration and very little room for other people's feelings,
- it doesn't change when the person is calm, rested and happy,
- it causes real, lasting harm to the person or to the people around them.

Not enough on its own:

- confidence, ambition or self-promotion at work,
- one selfish choice, or a defensive reaction to criticism,

- talking about yourself a lot when you're nervous,
- someone you've fallen out with.

Describing what happened helps more than a label. "You talked over me three times tonight" can be answered. A diagnosis thrown at someone in an argument usually ends the conversation, and it's often wrong. "Toxic" works the same way. It names no specific behavior and no effect over time, and a hard week, a single conflict or a bad day isn't enough to earn it.

Common mix-ups

You aren't simply an introvert or an extravert. Most people are somewhere in the middle, and where you sit shifts with the setting and your mood. Personality isn't set in stone by thirty, either. It keeps moving slowly all through life. Online type quizzes are good for fun and for starting a conversation, and that includes the website's own Wave Code, which shows four leanings on four dials, but they sort people into a handful of types when real people are spread along each dial. "They're just difficult" often means "they're different from me," and it can hide stress or illness or a need nobody has asked about. And practicing something new isn't being fake. It feels odd at first, like new shoes, and then it's yours.

If you want to help someone else with this

Drop the old labels, and notice if you still describe someone the way they were twenty years ago. Ask instead of guessing. "What helps you recharge?" or "How do you like to plan things?" will tell you more than any theory. Say it when you see someone grow, because "You handled that so calmly" can show a person a change they hadn't spotted. And describe what happened, not who

someone is. “You’re so uptight” shuts doors that a plain description would leave open.

> WORDS TO TRY
> “I used to think of you as the shy one. I don’t think that fits anymore.” “What do you need to be at your best this week?”

Tools **helpers you use on the website**

- How you connect: four quick dials for how you think, talk and listen. Its four-letter Wave Code is shorthand for four preferences, not a type.
- Communication style quiz.

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
How you connect: the 2-minute style quiz
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength

TOOL
Communication style quiz
spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication-style-quiz

More for your situation

- Chapter 2: your wiring, your weather and your words (page 25)
- Book 2, Chapter 6: Habits and change (page 101)
- Chapter 7: Minds that work differently (page 115)
- For parents · For teens · For grandparents
- Sharing a room · At work
- Help by relationship: find the pages for your situation.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
For parents
spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents

ONLINE
For teens
spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens

ONLINE
For grandparents
spreadloveandacceptance.com/grandparents

TOOL
Plan it once: room agreement for roommates
spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room

TOOL
Team job list: the 10-minute weekly round
spreadloveandacceptance.com/work

ONLINE
Help by relationship
spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship

THIS CONNECTS TO

Chapter 2 · Your wiring, weather and words page 25
Your wiring today

Chapter 1 · Where your lens came from page 7
Temperament and how you grew up

Chapter 7 · Minds that work differently page 115
Minds that work differently

Book 2, Chapter 6 · Habits and change Heal and Steady, page 101
How change really happens

PUT IT TO USE

How you connect: the 2-minute style quiz
Four quick dials for how you think, talk and listen. Its four-letter Wave Code is shorthand for four preferences, not a type
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength

Communication style quiz
spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication-style-quiz

Go deeper (free online) The expanded version of this chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-14-personality-in-depth

7

BOOK 1 · CHAPTER 7

Minds that work differently

How autistic, ADHD, sensory and learning differences work, why none of them is a character flaw, and how people with different minds can meet in the middle.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Brains vary, like bodies do
2. Autism is a different way of sensing and connecting
3. ADHD is about steering attention, not lacking it
4. Everyone has a sensory profile
5. Learning differences aren't about intelligence
6. Masking costs energy
7. Autistic burnout is more than being tired
8. Meltdowns and shutdowns aren't choices
9. Stimming helps, so let it be
10. Deep focus makes switching hard
11. Deep interests are a source of joy and rest
12. Meet in the middle, out loud
13. Labels are tools, and they belong to the person
14. Finding out later in life
15. Getting things started and finished is a skill of its own
16. When demands feel like a threat
17. Not recognizing faces isn't rudeness
18. Not speaking isn't the same as having nothing to say
19. Telling friends and dates is your choice
20. Finding your people
21. In everyday life
22. Common mix-ups
23. If you want to help someone else with this
24. More for your situation

AT A GLANCE

- **Brains vary, like bodies do.** A different mind is not a broken one, though differences can still be disabling in a world built for one kind of mind.

- **Nobody chooses overload.** Meltdowns, shutdowns and burnout are what happens when a nervous system has had too much.
- **Less masking, room to stim, time for deep interests and real rest** help a great deal.
- **Meet in the middle, out loud.** Ask what helps, say what helps you, and use the words each person chooses.

MONDAY, 8:15AM

"Shoes, please, just put them on," you say, for the third time.

Your son is lying on the hall floor with his hands over his ears. The new socks are wrong. From where you're standing, they are socks. From where he is, the seam across his toes is sandpaper, and the alarm clock upstairs that nobody has switched off is going straight through the middle of his head. You are already late. So is he, in a way you can't see.

This chapter is for neurodivergent people, diagnosed or not, and for the people who live and work with them. It can't diagnose anyone, and only you get to choose the words you use for yourself.

Two tools elsewhere rest on it. The "How to talk to me" card (Chapter 2, page 25) works because different minds need different input, and saying things plainly helps almost everyone. One owner per job and the written job list (Book 4, Chapter 2, page 27) move memory out of anyone's head and onto paper, which helps ADHD and autistic minds most and everybody a bit.

In quick strokes, a child on the hall floor with his hands over his ears is three things at once. On the surface, a fuss about socks. Underneath, a sensory system turned up high. Underneath that, a

morning with no room left in it. The roots are state and setting, and quiet incentives, what the setup rewards. The chapter then takes the ways minds differ one at a time.

01

Brains vary, like bodies do.

Brains differ in how they take in the world, focus, move, read, remember and connect with people. “Neurodiversity” is the idea that this variety is natural. “Neurodivergent” describes people whose minds work differently from what gets treated as typical. A different mind isn’t a broken one. Differences can still be disabling, though, especially in a world built for one kind of mind, and that is just as true.

Gary found out he was dyslexic at forty, and he sat in the car outside the assessment center for twenty minutes afterward with the report on the passenger seat, not reading it, obviously. What he mostly felt was relief. For thirty years he had half believed the teachers who wrote “lazy” in red pen.

02

Autism is a different way of sensing and connecting.

Autistic people often communicate more directly and literally. Many have deep, focused interests, feel senses more (or less) intensely than others do, and find predictability calming. Autism doesn’t run along one line from “mild” to “severe.” Each autistic person has their own mix of strengths and needs, which can change from day to day, and the misunderstandings between autistic and non-autistic people usually run both ways.

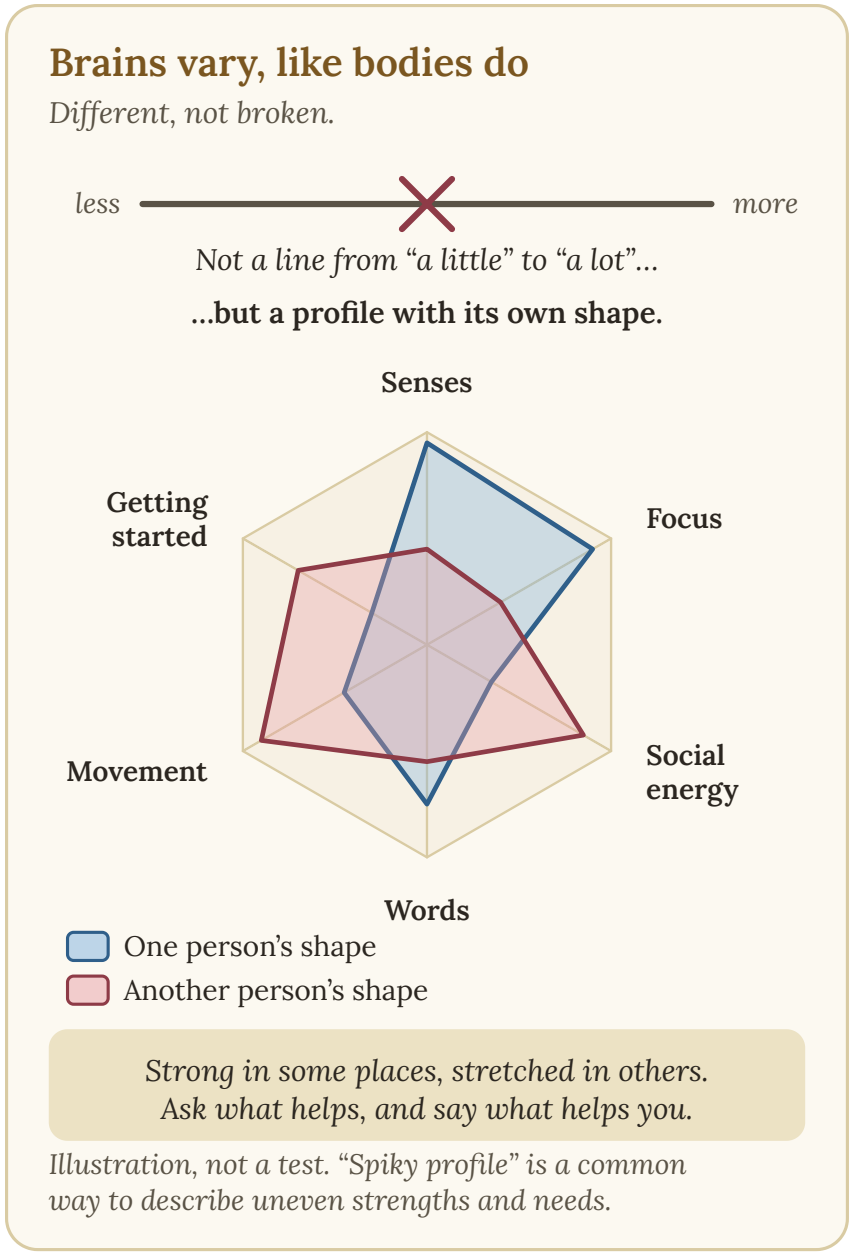


FIGURE 10 Brains vary, like bodies do. A mind has a profile with its own shape, not a place on a line from "a little" to "a lot." Different, not broken.

"Your slides have three typos," Kate told her colleague, kindly. "One on slide four and two on the summary." It was exactly what she

would have wanted to be told. He went quiet for the rest of the afternoon and she had no idea why until a mutual friend explained it to her at a bar. They were using two different sets of rules for what kindness sounds like, and neither set is wrong, though it would help if they came with subtitles. If you're the direct one, it can help to say so up front, something like "I like it when people say exactly what they mean, so you can be direct with me."

The story that got lost in the middle

In an experiment, a story was passed along chains of eight people. All-autistic chains kept as much detail as all-non-autistic ones, while mixed chains lost detail faster and reported less rapport, which supports the idea that the difficulty sits between two styles rather than inside one of them.

Crompton and colleagues (2020) · *Moderate: a careful experiment; modest sample, one task*

03

ADHD is about steering attention, not lacking it.

People with ADHD usually have plenty of attention, and the hard bit is pointing it. Boring tasks feel like pushing a car uphill, interesting ones swallow whole evenings, and time is slippery (there's "now" and there's "not now" and not much in between). Feelings arrive fast and big. It's a real difference in how the brain manages itself. Effort and caring don't come into it.

Saffy forgot her best friend's birthday. Completely. Not a text. Then she spent six hours making a card with pressed flowers from the yard, glued on one at a time with tweezers, and posted it four days late with a note that said "I KNOW." The forgetting and the six hours came out of the same brain. If something keeps falling out of yours, move it into the world. A labeled alarm. A note on the door. A basket by the front door for the keys.

04

Everyone has a sensory profile.

We all take in sound, light, touch, smell, taste, movement and signals from inside the body. Some people feel these strongly and get overloaded by noise, or a label in a sweater. Others need more input, like movement or strong flavors or firm pressure. Overload is a body at its limit, which is a very different thing from being fussy.

Two roommates fell out over the kitchen radio, because one found silence creepy and the other found the radio at breakfast physically painful. They settled on the radio until nine and headphones after, which has lasted two years.

Notice one sound, light or texture that drains you and one that calms you, and change one small thing today.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Knowing your own sensory profile is information, not a complaint. Write it down once and hand it over, and you don't have to explain it every time.

TOOL **How you connect: how I like to be spoken to** ·
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
How you connect: how I like to be spoken to
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card

05

Learning differences aren't about intelligence.

Dyslexia (reading and spelling), dyscalculia (numbers), dyspraxia (coordination and planning movement) and language disorders are specific differences, and none of them measures how clever someone is. Plenty of people have a "spiky" profile, very strong in some areas and struggling in others. The right tools, audiobooks or extra time on tests or a reader for the long letters, can level things a good deal.

Every Wednesday afternoon on the field, fourteen-year-old Ewan is called clumsy, usually by a gym teacher who should know better. The same semester he wrote and directed the school play, which had a revolving set made out of a bike wheel. Ask the people you live or work with how they find it easiest to take things in, and then actually use it.

06

Masking costs energy.

Many neurodivergent people learn to hide their differences. They copy other people, force eye contact, hold back movements, rehearse small talk in the car. This is called masking. It can get someone through a day. It also uses a great deal of energy, and over years it can wear a person down into exhaustion and burnout. For a long time the cost can be invisible even to the person paying it, which is rather the point of a mask.

Mia seems completely fine at college, chatty in the cafeteria and helpful in class and laughing in all the right places. She gets home at four fifteen, goes straight up to her room, and can't say a word to anyone for an hour. Her dad used to knock and ask what was wrong, and now he leaves a cup of tea outside the door and goes away.

Notice one place where you could drop the mask a little, and one person you can be fully yourself with. Spend a bit more time there.

Style, not substance
Across three studies, non-autistic people formed poorer first impressions of autistic people from a few seconds of video and were less keen to talk to them. Given only a transcript of what was said, the bias disappeared. That goes a long way to explaining why people mask.

Sasson and colleagues (2017) · *Moderate: three studies with consistent results*

07

Autistic burnout is more than being tired.

Autistic burnout is a deep, long-lasting exhaustion. Working with autistic adults, Raymaker and colleagues (2020) described it as long-term exhaustion, loss of skills (like speech, planning or self-care) and lower tolerance of noise, light and other input. It comes from long stress without enough support, and it often lasts months. Rest helps, and so do fewer demands and less masking. Pushing harder usually makes it worse. If you think you might be there, list three demands you could drop or hand to someone else for a month.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"I'm in burnout. What I need for a while is fewer demands." "I can't do phone calls at the moment. Can we message instead?"

08

Meltdowns and shutdowns aren't choices.

A **meltdown** is an involuntary loss of control when overwhelm gets too much, and it can look like crying, shouting, running off or lashing out. A **shutdown** is the quiet version: going still, losing speech, not being able to respond. Neither is a tantrum. In interviews by Phung and colleagues (2021), autistic young people

described meltdowns and shutdowns as separate experiences, both linked to overload.

For a lot of people words go first. What helps is less of everything. Less noise, fewer words, no questions, more space. Talking can wait, sometimes until the next day. On a calm day, agree a simple signal for "I'm overloaded" and a quiet place to go.

> WAYS TO SAY IT
> (to someone else) "You're safe. I'm right here. No need to talk."
> (for yourself) "I'm overloaded. I need quiet for twenty minutes."

09

Stimming helps, so let it be.

Stimming means repeated movements or sounds. Rocking, flapping, tapping, humming, pacing, fiddling with something. Most people stim a little. (Watch any meeting and count the jiggling feet.) For many autistic people it matters a lot. In interviews by Kapp and colleagues (2019), autistic adults described stimming as a way to cope with overwhelming emotions and sensations, and objected to efforts to stop harmless stimming. If it isn't hurting anyone, it doesn't need stopping. It's worth noticing what your own hands do when you're stressed or focused or happy, because that's yours, and nobody needs to train it out of you.

10

Deep focus makes switching hard.

Some minds go deep into one thing at a time, often autistic and ADHD ones. That focus can be a real strength, because it builds expertise and brings a great deal of joy, and it also makes switching hard. Being interrupted can feel like being yanked out of water.

"Dinner!" Nothing. "Tilly, dinner!" Still nothing. Third time, louder. The fish sticks are going cold and Dominic is getting really

frustrated. His daughter is upstairs building a castle and has reached a delicate stage with the drawbridge. The next night he tries a ten-minute warning, then a five. She comes down on time, still talking about the drawbridge, and tells him at length what the problem with it is. He doesn't entirely follow, but he eats his fish sticks while they're still warm, which is the main thing. The warning, for the record, goes "Dinner in ten minutes, I'll come and get you in five minutes," shouted up the stairs, and it works about four nights out of five.

11

Deep interests are a source of joy and rest.

Many autistic people have deep, intense interests, often called special interests. The theory of monotropism (Murray, Lesser and Lawson, 2005) describes autistic attention as pulled strongly into a few things at a time. In a survey of autistic adults by Grove and colleagues (2018), people who were more motivated by and engaged with their special interests reported higher well-being, though very intense engagement went with lower well-being.

Ask someone about their favorite subject and let them talk for five minutes without steering. It costs you five minutes. It's one of the warmest things you can do for anyone.

Interests and well-being
In a large Dutch survey of autistic adults, about two in three had a special interest, and being more motivated by it went with higher well-being. Very intense engagement went the other way. The joy is real, and so, some weeks, is the need for an off switch.

Grove and colleagues (2018) · *Moderate: a large survey, self-report, at one point in time*

12

Meet in the middle, out loud.

When two kinds of mind live or work together, neither should have to do all the adjusting. Clear, plain words help everyone. Say what you mean, give times, write things down, ask what helps. And changes made for one person (a quiet space, an agenda, flexible hours) usually help plenty of other people too.

A team started sending meeting agendas a day early, for one autistic colleague. Within a month most of them said meetings had gotten shorter. Two people who had never said a word in a meeting started saying things.

Today, swap one "how I work best" fact with someone. Tell them one thing that helps you and ask for one that helps them. The website can bend a bit to your mind too, with Read your way (bigger text, calmer pages, fewer surprises).

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 9

"How to talk to me" card, for work

An autistic employee, for a new manager

Your card

Who it's for

A partner · Family · A friend · *Work (a manager or coworker)*

Name on the card, optional

Tom

WIRING CARD · NOT A DIAGNOSIS

How I receive things best
A written list.

I take words
Literally.

Give me time to answer
Write it down so I can answer later.

Please avoid
A hard topic with no warning. Correcting me in public.

A request lands best as
"Could you ___ by ___?"

Also good to know about me
If I go quiet, I'm processing, not upset. Tell me the plan, and tell me if it changes. Noise, light or touch can wear me out.

Sensory needs
Short breaks in long talks.

Sent with one line: "Here's a short card about how I work best. It's not a request for anything big; it just helps us avoid crossed wires."

Sharing a card is always the person's own choice.

Fill in your own: "How to talk to me" card

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Read your way
spreadloveandacceptance.com/how-you-take-things-in

TOOL
How you connect: how I like to be spoken to
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card

13

Labels are tools, and they belong to the person.

A diagnosis can bring understanding, and sometimes support and a community too. Some people find their way to a label through self-discovery first. Many autistic adults prefer "autistic person" and others prefer "person with autism." The kindest rule is to ask, use the words the person chooses, and never try to diagnose somebody else, least of all in an argument.

The fight was about the dishes. It was going badly. "You're so autistic," Danny said, and the conversation ended right there, as it deserved to. In the morning, over toast that neither of them was eating, he said sorry, properly, and then asked what his partner actually needed from him when the kitchen was a mess. It was the conversation they should have had the night before.

If you've wondered about yourself, write down what you've noticed and pick one small next step, like talking it over with someone you trust.

14

Finding out later in life.

More and more adults are finding out they're autistic, or have ADHD, in their thirties or fifties or seventies. Many were missed as children, especially women. In interviews by Leedham and colleagues (2020), women diagnosed at forty or older described how exhausting it had been to go so long without an explanation, and how much the diagnosis changed the way they understood their own lives. Relief and grief and something like joy can all turn up together, on the same afternoon. If that's you, look for one autistic-led group or online space, and give yourself time.

15

Getting things started and finished is a skill of its own.

Planning, starting, switching, remembering what you were doing and keeping track of time are called **executive function**. Many autistic and ADHD people find some of these harder, and harder on some days than others. A review of 235 studies by Demetriou and colleagues (2018) found differences in executive function in autism on average, with a lot of variation between people. The brain's self-management system is working differently. Laziness doesn't come into it.

Siân wrote a forty-page report for her board in a week, and it was excellent. In those same weeks, she could not mail one package. It sat on the hall table while she walked past it forty times. Then she put it by the front door with a yellow sticky note on top ("MAIL ME") and set an alarm for Tuesday at 8:10, and on Tuesday at 8:11 it went. See routines that help and Wired differently.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
routines that help
spreadloveandacceptance.com/adhd-kids

ONLINE
Wired differently
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wired-differently

16

When demands feel like a threat.

Some people, often autistic, feel strong anxiety when asked or expected to do things, even things they want to do. Avoiding the demand can look like refusing, joking, changing the subject or a meltdown. The profile was first described as "pathological demand avoidance," or PDA, by Newson and colleagues (2003).

It isn't in the main diagnostic manuals, and researchers disagree about it. A review by Kildahl and colleagues (2021) found the evidence limited and mostly based on parent reports. Many people who identify with it prefer the phrase "persistent drive for autonomy." Honestly, I'd hold this one loosely until the research settles. What helps tends to be the same whatever it's called. Less pressure. Requests that feel like invitations. "Put your coat on now" gets a flat no from Reuben every morning. "It's cold out. Coat or sweater, your choice?" gets the coat, usually.

17

Not recognizing faces isn't rudeness.

Prosopagnosia, or face blindness, means finding it hard to recognize faces, sometimes even close friends seen out of context. It can be something you're born with. Many autistic people also find remembering faces harder, as a review by Weigelt and colleagues (2012) found. People who don't recognize you may be relying on your voice, your hair, your coat or where they usually see you.

Clive walked straight past his neighbor in the supermarket without a flicker, and she went home feeling snubbed and told her sister about it on the phone. When he explained, a week later and very embarrassed, that he hadn't known her without her spaniel, she laughed. Now she says "Hi Clive, it's Jo from number twelve" every time, even when the spaniel is right there.

> WORDS TO TRY
> "I'm bad with faces, so please say who you are when you say hi." (to someone else) "Hi, it's Jo from next door."

18

Not speaking isn't the same as having nothing to say.

Some autistic people speak rarely, sometimes or not at all, and some lose speech when stressed. Many communicate through **AAC** (augmentative and alternative communication), which can mean typing, letter boards, picture cards, apps or sign. Using AAC doesn't stop speech developing: a review by Millar, Light and Schlosser (2006) found it did not hold speech back, and may help it. The safest place to start is to presume competence, which means assuming the person understands and has something to say, and giving them the time and the tools to say it.

At Sunday lunch at her grandma's, fifteen-year-old Ruby types on her tablet. Her uncle used to talk about her across the table as if she wasn't there ("Does she want gravy?"). Now he asks her, and waits, a bit longer than he'd like, while she types. Her answer was "Yes. Obviously." Wait longer than feels natural, which will feel very long and isn't.

19

Telling friends and dates is your choice.

Whether to tell someone you're autistic or ADHD, and when, is up to you. Telling can bring understanding. In a study by Sasson and Morrison (2019), people formed better first impressions of autistic adults when they knew they were autistic, especially if they knew more about autism.

People don't always respond well, though, and interviews by Au-Yeung and colleagues (2025) describe autistic adults weighing hope for support against fear of not being believed. Many share a little at a time, starting with what helps and leaving the label for later. Second date, outside a bar with a line. "I'm autistic," Nina said, "so I'm quite direct, and I'd rather walk than sit in there." Her date looked at the bar, then the line, then back at her. "Oh, thank

God," he said. They walked along the canal as far as the lock and back.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
> "I'm autistic. For me that means…" "I won't always pick up hints, so please just tell me." (if someone shares with you) "Thanks for telling me. What helps?"

20

Finding your people.

Lots of autistic people describe meeting other autistic people as a turning point, because at last they don't have to translate or explain or mask. The research backs this up. Cooper, Smith and Russell (2017) found that autistic people who felt more connected to other autistic people had higher self-esteem, and through that, less anxiety and depression. Being autistic can be an identity and a community as well as a diagnosis.

After his diagnosis at fifty-three, Bernard joined an online group of autistic adults who love old maps, specifically the USGS kind with hand-drawn hachures. The first evening he talked to them for three hours about contour lines. When he logged off he had more energy than when he'd started, which hadn't happened after a conversation in years.

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can't change how your brain, or anyone else's, is wired. You can learn how yours works and say what helps, and ask others what helps them. Meeting in the middle means both people move a little. If you're always the one adjusting, it's fair to say so. More in Your wiring, weather and words (Chapter 2, page 25)

MONDAY, 8:30AM

You stop asking. You sit down on the hall floor next to him, which is cold, and say, "Socks feel wrong?" He nods without opening his eyes. You go upstairs, switch the alarm clock off, dig the old seamless pair out of the laundry basket. Two minutes later his shoes are on. You're ten minutes late and nobody has shouted, which on a Monday is about as good as it gets. That night you order three more pairs and let him pick the colors.

TWO WAYS TO READ THIS

Wearing headphones at the dinner table

FROM OUTSIDE At a family meal, one person has headphones in.

THE LOGIC Sound arrives whether you want it or not. A brain that filters less hears all of it at once. Filtering by hand uses up attention. Headphones do the filtering, so there is attention left for people.

IT'S LIKE Sunglasses on a bright day. You still see everything, without squinting.

WHY IT FITS Many people take in more of the background noise. One theory links this to how much the brain smooths out what it hears.

THE OTHER SIDE The family may feel shut out of the meal.

YOU COULD SAY *"These help me stay at the table."*

ONE SMALL STEP Agree a tap on the arm that means "I'm talking to you," and take one ear out when it comes.

BOTH DIRECTIONS Some brains filter background sound without trying, so a busy kitchen is just company. Others take in every clatter, voice and hum at once, and filtering it by hand uses up the attention they wanted for the people. If you filter easily, headphones at the table can look like shutting everyone out, and for the other person they're how they stay at the table at all. If you hear everything, it may help to say so: "The headphones mean I can stay. Talk to me and I'll take one out."

WHERE THE FIELDS MEET Holistic therapies start with the body before the argument, which fits overload well: less noise, fewer words, settle first and talk later. Some of these practices are well studied and some are debated, so only the plain everyday parts are used here. The root underneath is quiet incentives, because a setup that only rewards masking will get a lot of masking.

More situations like this one, each in the same six parts, are free online.
spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=headphones

In everyday life

On your own

Knowing how your mind works helps you build a life that fits it, and spot burnout before it's on top of you (see Get to know your wiring, spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path). Partners can swap "how I work best" notes about plans, messages, touch and time alone. With children, behavior very often has a sensory or overload reason, so "What's too much right now?" is worth asking before "Why are you doing this?" A friend who cancels at the last minute may just be out of energy, and offering something easier, like a walk, keeps the door open. At work, written agendas, clear deadlines and quiet spaces help far more people than the ones they were made for.

If you have ADHD and share a home, make the chore tools lighter. Log three days instead of seven, with a tally on the fridge. Own a few jobs completely, each with a labeled alarm, instead of helping a bit with everything. Forgetting is a setup problem to fix together. More in the expanded version.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Get to know your wiring
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path

Common mix-ups

"Everyone's a bit autistic" is probably the commonest, and it makes real needs sound small. Everyone shares some traits, but autism is

a whole pattern, present across life. ADHD doesn't just mean not sitting still. Many people with it, girls and women especially, are mostly inattentive or restless on the inside. "They seem fine to me" overlooks how much masking can hide, and seeming fine can cost someone their whole evening. Adjustments aren't special treatment; they remove a barrier, the way glasses do. And the idea that autistic people lack empathy is simply out of date. Many feel other people's feelings very strongly, and the differences in how empathy is shown run both ways.

If you want to help someone else with this

Believe them about what's hard and what helps, even when it's different for you. Be clear, which means saying what you mean, giving times and writing down anything important. Ask what helps, because every neurodivergent person is different and their answer will beat any list, this one included. Protect their energy. Quiet time, warnings before changes and a way out of loud places matter more than they look. And enjoy their interests with them, if you can.

> WAYS TO SAY IT
>
> "Is there anything about this place, or this plan, that would make it hard for you?" "You don't have to explain. Just tell me what you need."

Tools helpers you use on the website

- Communication style quiz for a friendly look at how you send and receive words

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
Communication style quiz
spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication-style-quiz

More for your situation

- **Couples:** Neurodivergent relationships
- **Parents and grandparents:** When a child has ADHD · Neurodivergent families
- **At work:** Neurodiversity at work · Autistic at work
- **Teens:** For teens
- **Sharing a home:** Sharing a room
- **On your own:** Get to know your wiring · Your wiring, weather and words (Chapter 2, page 25)
- **Related chapters:** Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (Chapter 5, page 79) · Loss, grief and big life changes (Book 2, Chapter 4, page 65)

Find your own starting point: Help by relationship.

FOR AUTISTIC READERS. If you are autistic, or wondering, several pieces were written with you in mind. Masking and autistic burnout are covered earlier in this chapter, and When feelings are hard to name (Chapter 2, page 32) looks at alexithymia. The double empathy problem explains why misunderstandings run both ways, the wiring card gives you a one-page "how I work best" card to share, and Autistic at work has words for asking for what you need.

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
Neurodivergent relationships · Neurodivergent families
spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships



ONLINE
When a child has ADHD
spreadloveandacceptance.com/adhd-kids



ONLINE
Neurodiversity at work · Autistic at work
spreadloveandacceptance.com/work



ONLINE
For teens
spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens



TOOL
Plan it once: room agreement for roommates
spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room



ONLINE
Get to know your wiring
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path



ONLINE
Help by relationship
spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship



ONLINE
The double empathy problem
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wired-differently



TOOL
How you connect: how I like to be spoken to
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card

THIS CONNECTS TO

Chapter 2 · Your wiring, weather and words page 25
Getting to know your own wiring

Book 3, Chapter 1 · Why we get out of tune Understanding Each Other, page 7
Pace, tone and meeting in the middle

Chapter 6 · Personality, temperament and change page 97
Dials, not boxes

Book 3, Chapter 2 · How communication works Understanding Each Other, page 23
Saying it so it lands for different minds

PUT IT TO USE

Communication style quiz
For a friendly look at how you send and receive words
spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication-style-quiz

How you connect: how I like to be spoken to
A one-page "how I communicate" card to share
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card

Go deeper (free online) The expanded version of this chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-9-minds-in-depth

Questions people ask

Some questions this book tends to raise, with short answers and where to read more.

Do I need to remember my childhood clearly for the first chapter to help?

Most people remember a handful of scenes and a general feeling, and that is plenty. The first chapter asks about the rules your home ran on, such as how feelings were handled or who did the worrying. Those rules tend to show up in how you react today more than in any one memory, so start with one rule you can name. Where your lens came from (Chapter 1, page 7) walks you through it.

What if looking back brings up something painful?

Stop there, and come back another day if you want to. Nobody has to finish a page.

I think I might be autistic or have ADHD. Can this book tell me?

It can't, and nothing in it is a test. Minds that work differently (Chapter 7, page 115) describes how some minds work, so that you might recognize yourself or someone you love, and it says who can talk you through an assessment if you want one. Plenty of people find the descriptions useful whether or not they ever look for a diagnosis.

Can a grown-up really change their personality?

A little, slowly, and mostly by practicing the thing you want to be more like. Personality, temperament and change (Chapter 6, page 97) treats traits as dials that move a few notches over the years. Every setting has its gifts and its costs, so the aim is a better fit with your life more than a new you.

My partner isn't interested in any of this. Is it still worth reading?

Yes. This book is about you, and it works if you are the only person in your home who ever opens it. Knowing your own wiring and weather makes it easier to say what you need, and the people around you often notice the change before they notice the book. If you later want to look at things together, Book 3 and Book 4 are written for that.

If you're having thoughts of hurting yourself or not wanting to be here, please tell someone you trust today.

Workpapers and tools in this book

Every workpaper and tool this book points to, in two separate lists, with the chapters and pages that mention each one. All of them are free at spreadloveandacceptance.com, with no account, and what you type stays on your device.

Workpapers mentioned in this book

Pages to fill out, on your own or together.

WORKPAPER WP-02 **How much are you carrying?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-02

In: Your wiring, weather and words (page 25)

WORKPAPER WP-04 **What keeps coming back?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-04

In: Who you are becoming (page 45)

WORKPAPER WP-11 **The Calm-Down Kit** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11

In: Your wiring, weather and words (page 25), Who you are becoming (page 45), How feelings work (page 61)

Tools mentioned in this book

Interactive helpers to use on the site.

TOOL **Rewind the talk** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder

In: Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page 79)

TOOL **Small wins: Flip it** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins

In: Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page 79)

TOOL **Stay close** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding

In: How feelings work (page 61)

TOOL **How you connect: the 2-minute style quiz** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength

In: Where your lens came from (page 7), Your wiring, weather and words (page 25), Who you are becoming (page 45), Personality, temperament and change (page 97)

TOOL **How you connect: how I like to be spoken to** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card

In: Your wiring, weather and words (page 25), Personality, temperament and change (page 97), Minds that work differently (page 115)

TOOL **Old rules, new choices** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up

In: Where your lens came from (page 7)

TOOL **Cool-down corner: Upset right now?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

In: How feelings work (page 61), Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page 79)

TOOL **My weather today** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

In: Your wiring, weather and words (page 25), How feelings work (page 61)

TOOL **Write it through** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/write-it-through

In: Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page 79)

TOOL **Ask Professor Puddles** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask

In: Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page 79)

TOOL **Read your way** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/how-you-take-things-in

In: Minds that work differently (page 115)

TOOL **Gentle games: the Re-check Drive (calm football)** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/recheck-drive

In: Who you are becoming (page 45)

TOOL **Plan it once: handoff bag for two homes** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting

In: Who you are becoming (page 45)

TOOL **Plan it once: room agreement for roommates** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room

In: Who you are becoming (page 45), Personality, temperament and change (page 97), Minds that work differently (page 115)

TOOL **Team job list: the 10-minute weekly round** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/work

In: Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page 79), Personality, temperament and change (page 97), Minds that work differently (page 115)

TOOL **Ten-minute start** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/start-in-10-minutes`
In: Who you are becoming (page 45)

TOOL **Communication style quiz** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication-style-quiz`
In: Personality, temperament and change (page 97), Minds that work differently (page 115)

Words used in this book

The book's own words, each in one plain sentence. All of them are at spreadloveandacceptance.com/glossary.

Alexithymia
Finding it hard to notice, name or describe your own feelings. It is a trait on a scale, not an illness, and it is more common in some autistic people. Naming body signals first can help.

Battery
Your battery is how much energy you have left today. Full means you have room to spare; low means you're running on empty. "How much are you carrying?" measures the other side of it, how full your stress tank is: a fuller tank means a lower battery.

Calm-Down Kit
Your Calm-Down Kit is your own short list of what settles your body, chosen ahead of time so you don't have to think when you're wound up.

Check-in
A check-in is a short, planned talk that keeps small things small. The daily one takes about ninety seconds, with no debating.

Double empathy
The idea, from the autistic researcher Damian Milton, that misunderstandings between autistic and non-autistic people run both ways: each finds the other hard to read, so neither side is simply "missing" something.

If-then plan
A small plan written as "If this happens, then I will do that," which makes a new habit easier to start (Peter Gollwitzer).

The ladder
Three everyday states: calm and connected, revved up, running on empty. My weather today calls them clear, gusty and fogged in. A best guess about your state, not a measurement.

The load
The load is all the work of a shared life, including the thinking, planning and remembering that nobody sees.

Masking
Masking is hiding the way you're wired to fit in, which can be very tiring over time.

Monotropism
A theory of autistic attention: attention gathers deeply on a few things at a time, rather than spreading thinly across many. Switching away can take real effort.

My weather today
My weather today is a one-minute check on your own conditions today, like sleep, stress and energy: Clear means calm and connected, Gusty means revved up, and Fogged in means running on empty.

Owner (one owner per job)

The owner of a job is the one person who makes sure it gets done from start to finish, so nobody has to keep asking.

Pressure

Pressure, in My weather today, is how much you were already carrying today: light, building or heavy. Behind the forecast sits a rough tally from 0 to 100; under 45 leaves room in the day, 65 or more means go gently. It is a reading of what you told it, not a score or a grade.

Repair

A repair is anything that stops a tense moment from getting worse, like a joke, a softer tone or "Can we start over?"

The rulebook from home

The rulebook from home is the unwritten set of rules you grew up with, about love, upset, chores and rest, that you may still expect others to follow.

Second arrow

The extra pain we add on top of a hard moment, such as being angry at ourselves for being sad. The first arrow is the event; the second is what we tell ourselves about it (a Buddhist image).

Stress tank

How much stress you are already carrying, from How much are you carrying?, scored from 0 (empty) to 1 (full). Under 0.30 is light, 0.30 to 0.59 medium, 0.60 and up high. A fuller tank means less room to take more on. (Your battery is the other side of it: energy left.)

Talk window

The talk window says whether now is a good time for a big conversation: open, wait a little, or closed for today.

Wave Code

Four letters from the style quiz in How you connect, one for each of four preferences about how you take in and send words. Each letter shows where you lean on a dial today: a shorthand for preferences, not a personality type.

Wired differently

Being wired differently means your brain works in a less common way, such as being autistic, ADHD, dyslexic or highly sensitive, which changes how words land.

Wiring

Your wiring is the way your brain and senses take in words, sound, change and people. It stays the same from day to day.

Workpaper

A page you fill in, on your own or with someone, about your own week or your own side. Every workpaper is free to print or to fill out on the website.

Your lens

Your lens is the set of understandings about yourself, other people and what they owe you that you picked up growing up and still use without noticing.

How the ideas connect

Many fields of study turn up in this book, from music to economics, and underneath them the same seven roots keep showing through. Learn a root once and you can carry it from one field to the next: if a budget needs a safety margin, so does a tired person.

Neurobiology
Your state sets the volume.
Chapter 2

Psychology
Intent isn't impact.
Chapter 4

Philosophy
Separate the fact from the guess.
Chapter 1

The art of debating
Separate the claim from the person.
Chapter 5

Politics
A fair way to decide, and a say for everyone.
Chapter 1

Economics
Attention is a budget.
Chapter 6

Business
One owner per job, and a simple check.
Chapter 6

THE SEVEN ROOTS

Balance what flows in has to match what flows out 3, 5

Signal and noise what's sent isn't always what arrives 4, 5

Feedback loops small things repeated, with a check each time, shape the whole 3

Limited capacity everything has a limit 2, 6

Ownership and structure work that belongs to everyone belongs to no one 1, 6

Quiet incentives things drift toward whatever the setup quietly rewards 7

State and setting the same message lands differently depending on the state you're in and the place you're in 2, 4, 7

Behavioral science
Habits beat good intentions.
Chapter 3

Finance
Every entry has two sides.
Chapter 3

Holistic therapies
Start with the body, then the argument.
Chapter 7

Laughter therapy
A shared laugh tells the body it's safe.
Chapter 5

Music
Tone and tempo carry more than the words.
Chapter 4

Aromatherapy
The setting matters.
Chapter 2

Holistic therapies, laughter and aromatherapy appear only in their plain, everyday parts. The research on them is modest or still growing.

Research notes

The 110 references these chapters draw on, briefly. Each one was looked up and checked. The full list, with what each study found, how strong the finding is and where to read it, is free online:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/research.

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